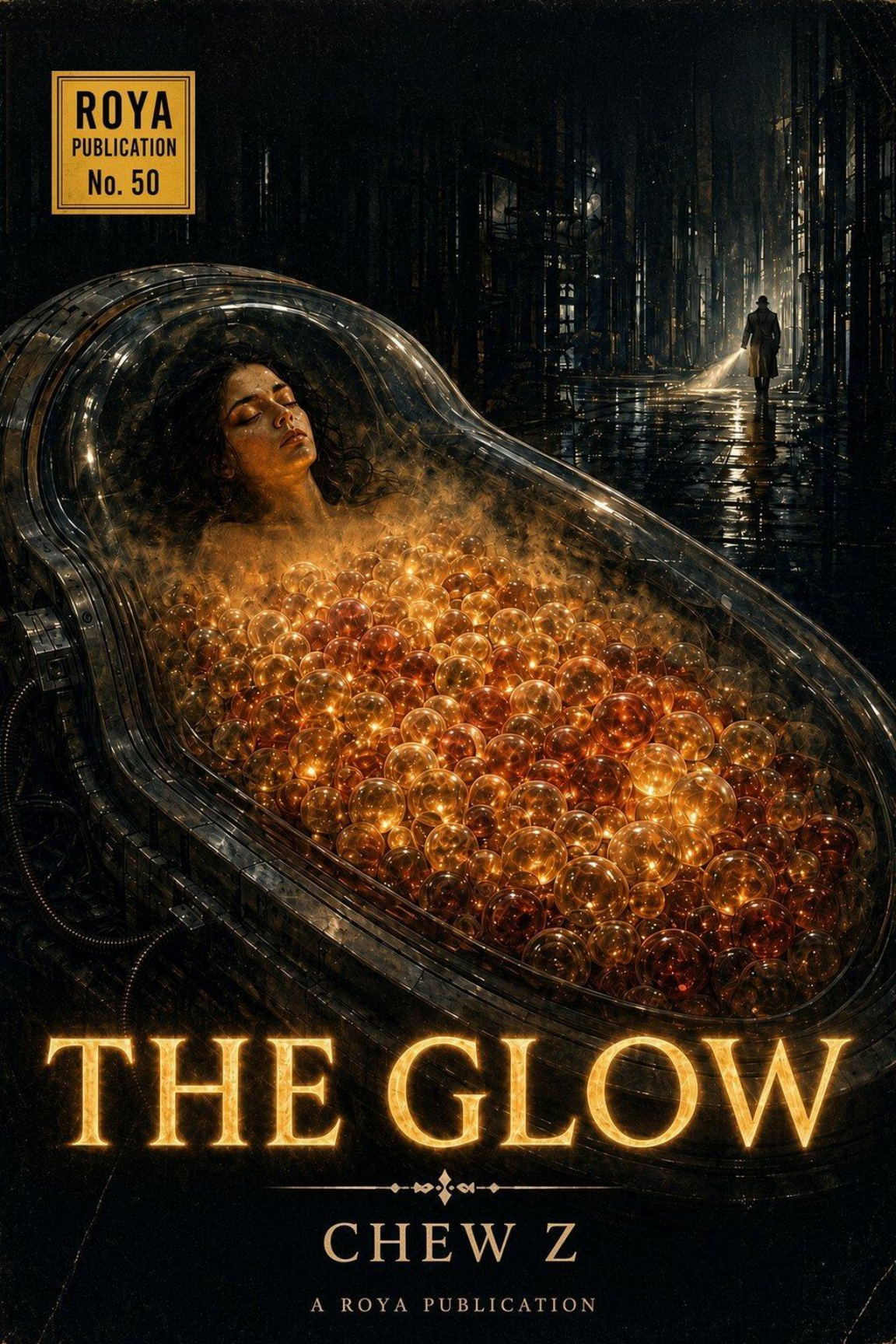

ROYA
PUBLICATION
No. 50
THE GLOW
CHEW Z
A ROYA PUBLICATION

THE GLOW

CHEW Z

Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 50

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

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ISBN 979-8-952790-49-0

Roya Publications

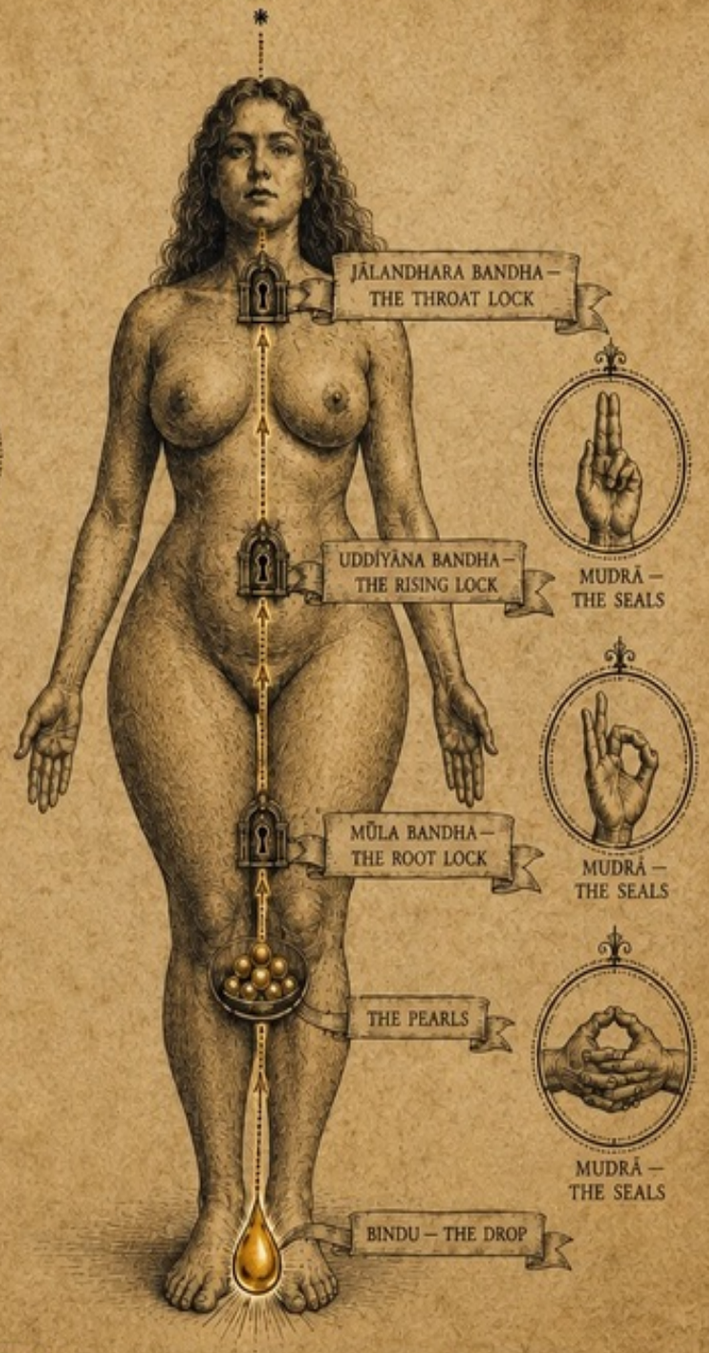
Publication No. 50

Typeset in DejaVu Serif.

Printed in the Reach

PLATE I — THE HELD ASCENT

from the monograph of M. Casta, Zurich





MUDRĀ — THE SEALS

MUDRĀ — THE SEALS



MUDRĀ — THE SEALS

MUDRĀ — THE SEALS



MUDRĀ — THE SEALS

MUDRĀ — THE SEALS

The final instruction was never committed to writing.

PLATE II — THE PEARL CYCLE

from the monograph of M. Casta, Zurich



I. THE CALIBRATED DROP — one delivery



II. THE SETTLING — it implants in the living lining, and nowhere else

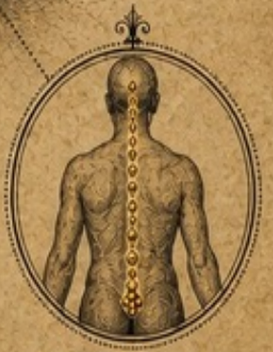




III. THE WHISPER — a continuous low voice in the body's own dialects



IV. THE INCREASE — each pearl the seed of the next



V. THE ASCENT — a centimeter a year, a vertebra a decade

It does not sit in the body like an implant.
It joins the body like a habit.

SYNOPSIS

Shirin Nouri [shee-REEN noo-REE] brings people into the world for a living. Mehrdad Āstāneh [mehr-DAAD aas-TAA-neh] builds entrances — the eleven seconds in which a person stops being outside a building and starts being inside one. They have a lake, a hut and a boat that leaks, and they have never once fixed it.

Then something arrives that nobody votes for.

It began as a study of women who had spent forty years learning to hold a pleasure instead of spending it. Copied, cultured and delivered in nineteen minutes through a fine tube, it becomes a settlement in the flesh: a continuous, costless ecstasy needing no partner, no occasion and no permission. It does not end.

Offered first to the women for whom nothing has worked, it works. Then it is offered to everyone, then subsidised, then expected, then administered in sleep.

Shirin takes it at forty-seven, with Mehrdad in the room, and he watches the woman he has loved for nineteen years become completely, permanently and genuinely well.

He is left holding a shared past alone, and learns what everybody learns too late: that missing someone is not the price of having had them. It is the last place they still are.

Nobody is persecuted. Nobody is lied to. The instruments are not wrong.

And the old manuals that mapped all of this, eight hundred years before anyone could open a body and look, wrote the method down and left out the last instruction on purpose.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

This book began with an indecent question and I am not going to pretend otherwise.

The ordinary orgasm lasts a few seconds. A small number of people, inside the clinical literature and outside it, report states that run for minutes, for an hour, in rare cases for most of a night. That is an enormous gap inside a single species, and the first thing I wanted to know was how far it goes.

Then the better question arrived underneath it, which is whether the body is built to survive it at all.

Every other appetite comes with a stop. Hunger stops. Thirst stops. Even pain, given long enough, dulls itself and lets you sleep. This one stops too, hard and early, and I could not work out what the stopping was *for*. It is possible that the brevity is not a limitation. It is possible that the brevity is the design.

Two real traditions sit under this book and I have tried not to muddle them, because almost everybody does.

The *Kamasutra* [KAA-muh-SOO-truh] is the older of the two and it is not the book it is famous for being. Vatsyayana [vaat-syaa-YUH-nuh] wrote it in Sanskrit, somewhere in northern India, in the early centuries of the common era. It runs to seven books and thirty-six chapters, and the part everybody knows is one book of the seven. The rest is about how to find somebody, how to live with them, how to furnish the room, how to be forgiven. Its whole subject is two people. It never argues for the two; it assumes them, the way you assume a floor.

The chakra [CHUK-ruh] material is a different tradition, centuries later — the tantric and hatha yoga texts, written by people whose interest was not two but one. They wanted to know whether a body could complete its own circuit. They worked on that for a very long time with no instrument except themselves, and I have come to think they solved it, and the solution is the thing this book is frightened of.

What is real: Vatsyayana, the structure and content of his book, the couch with the lute on a peg. The seven stations and their Sanskrit names and literal meanings. The locks, the sealed vessel, the reversal, the claim that the practice stops the burning. The tradition's insistence that one final instruction was never written down, and the reason they gave.

What is invented is everybody in it, and the thing that is done to them.

I did not want to write about a villain and there isn't one. Nobody in this book does anything cruel. A good thing is made available to people who need it, and then to people who would merely prefer it, and then it is the water supply — and at no point in that sequence is there a sentence anybody could reasonably refuse.

The part I keep coming back to is the smallest. The old writers were not against pleasure; they were the only people in history who took it seriously enough to spend eight centuries on it. And having built the thing, they looked at what they had built and decided that the dangerous half was not the holding.

It was the not-letting-go. And they would not write that down, because it was the one part that had to be handed over by a person, in a room, to another person who was ready.

I have spent a long time thinking about what a tradition has to know before it does that.

Chew Z

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THE BOOK OF DESIRE

Somewhere in northern India, about seventeen hundred years ago, a man sat down to write a book about how to live.

His name was Vatsyayana [vaat-syaa-YUH-nuh]. We know almost nothing else about him. He says at the end of his book that he wrote it in chastity and contemplation, which may be a joke, and may not be, and there is no longer anybody to ask.

He believed that a human life had three things to get right. The first was *dharma* [DHUR-muh] — doing what you ought to do. The second was *artha* [UR-thuh] — getting and keeping what you need. And the third was *kama* [KAA-muh], which has no good English word, and which is the reason you are holding this book.

Kama is pleasure. Not happiness, which is a weather of the mind. Pleasure: the thing that happens in the body when the body is pleased. A peach. Cold water. Music heard rather than listened to. A hand on the back of your neck.

He thought it needed studying, the way medicine needed studying, or architecture, or war. He thought it was difficult and that people were bad at it. And so he wrote his book, and called it the *Kamasutra* [KAA-muh-SOO-truh] — which means, exactly and unglamorously, *the thread of pleasure*, a sutra being a thread, the line a teaching is strung along so that it can be carried without being dropped.

It is not the book you think it is.

Seven books, thirty-six chapters, and only one of those books is about what to do with your body. The rest is about how to find somebody. How to make a home. How to behave when you are married, and how to behave when you should not be. How to furnish a room. There is a passage on the correct way to keep a garden, and one on the proper arrangement of a couch — a couch with soft cushions and a canopy, two pillows, a low table, and near it a lute hanging on a peg, because the kind of life Vatsyayana was describing is the kind in which somebody might want a lute at short

notice.

He is writing about a whole life with pleasure in it. The famous chapter is twelve pages in a book about everything.

And the thing I want you to carry out of this opening is what he assumed so completely that he never argued for it, the way a man does not argue that water is wet.

He assumed there would be two of you.

Every page of it is two people. The whole architecture of the thing — the approaching, the courting, the quarrelling, the forgiving, the long practical business of sharing a roof with somebody who wants different things at different hours — is a technology for getting one human being into the same room as another and keeping them there. The pleasure is not the achievement. The pleasure is the proof that the difficult thing worked.

He had no idea this would ever need saying.

—

Now the second tradition, because this is a book about what happened when the two got confused.

Centuries after Vatsyayana — a long way after, five hundred years, a thousand, the dates are argued about and the arguing does not matter here — other people in the same part of the world began writing a different kind of manual.

They were not interested in two of you. They were interested in one.

Their question was not how to give pleasure or receive it. It was stranger, and it is the question this whole history turns on:

What is pleasure for, and what would happen if you did not let it finish?

They had noticed what everybody notices and almost nobody examines, which is that the thing is *brief*. It builds, it arrives, it is over, and the body afterwards is quiet and a little stupid and glad. Seconds. For something the species organises its entire life around, a handful of seconds.

They wanted to know whether that was a limit or a decision.

So they went looking inside the body for the machinery, with no instruments at all except the body, and they found — or decided, or inherited, and I will not pretend to know which — a map.

The map said: a person is not one thing. A person is a column, and the column has stations.

They called the stations wheels. The word is *chakra* [CHUK-ruh], and it is not a mystical word at all; it is the ordinary word for a cartwheel, the thing on the ox-cart outside. Seven of them, stacked from the floor of you to the top of your head, each turning on its own, the cart only moving when they turn together.

There is going to be an interlude for each one.

I want to say plainly what they are and what they are not, because the subject attracts a kind of writing that helps nobody. Nobody has ever found a chakra with a knife. They are not organs. What they are is a very old, very careful attempt to describe where things are *felt* — and on that, which is the only claim they ever actually made, they are extraordinarily accurate. Fear is felt in the belly. Grief is felt in the chest. Shame goes up the throat and stops there. Every language on earth knows this and puts it in its idioms, and these people simply sat down and wrote the list.

So read the interludes as what they are. A field guide to the inside of a person, compiled before anybody could see inside a person, by people who had nothing to work with except being one.

Seven stations. We will climb them one at a time, from the floor to the crown.

I should tell you now that something else climbs them too.

—

One last thing before we begin, and it is the only promise I will make.

The second tradition solved their problem. That is not a figure of speech and it is not a claim about the supernatural. They found out how to make it last — minutes, then an hour, then in the oldest accounts from dusk until light — and they wrote the method down in careful, patient, unmystical detail, across eight centuries and three scripts, step by step.

And then, at the very end of the sequence, every version of it stops.

There is one final instruction. It is attested everywhere and written nowhere. The commentaries agree that it is short, that it is essential, and that without it the practice is not a practice but an injury. It was never committed to writing in any century. It passed from a living teacher to a living student, in a room, by mouth, and only when the teacher judged the student ready.

They had a reason. They stated it, and it is the one sentence the whole tradition was built to protect, and I have had a very long time to think about it:

The technique must never travel without a person attached.

Hold on to that. You will be given it back.

I. THE LAKE

1. BAIL OR ROW

The boat leaked from the first summer and they never fixed it.

That is where I want to start, because everything else in this history is a consequence, and because of all the facts I hold about Shirin Nouri [shee-REEN noo-REE] and Mehrdad Āstāneh [mehr-DAAD aas-TAA-neh] — and I hold a great many, more than either of them ever knew existed — this is the one I would keep if I were only allowed one.

It was somebody's uncle's hut, two hours out of the city, on a lake that had no particular reputation. Pines came down to the water on three sides and stopped a few metres short, so there was a lip of pale stones all the way round, and the stones held the day's heat until well after dark. The water was cold at the top and colder underneath, and the cold underneath arrived at your ankles without warning, like a hand. At six in the evening the whole surface went the colour of beaten tin and the far shore turned into one unbroken black shape with no trees in it, just a shape, and the light that was left came up at you off the water instead of down from the sky, so that for about forty minutes every clear evening the two of them were lit from below like people on a stage.

The boat was wooden and bad. Somebody had painted it green a long time ago and the green had gone the way green goes. It took on water through a seam near the bow at a rate that Mehrdad, who was an architect and could not help it, measured once with a cup and a watch and announced as a litre every eleven minutes.

Fixing it would have taken an afternoon. There was always something better to do with an afternoon.

So the boat worked like this: one of you rowed and one of you bailed, and you swapped, and if you did not swap at roughly the right time there was a conversation about it.

They had that conversation once, properly, out in the middle, in the second summer. It started as a joke and stopped being one somewhere around the third exchange, and it went on for eleven or twelve minutes and covered, in the way these things do, considerably more ground than a boat. Whose turn it was. Whether keeping track of turns was itself a kind of accounting that a person

should be ashamed of. Whether the one who had raised the question had raised it because of the turns or because of a thing that had happened on Tuesday. Whether Tuesday was now on the table.

Tuesday was on the table.

They got back to the hut at dusk with their feet wet, not speaking. He went in and she stayed on the stones. Then she came in, and there was a further ten minutes of the particular silence of two people in one room who have each independently decided to be the better person and are each waiting to be allowed to, and then she said *bail or row* in a voice that was doing an impression of his voice, and it was not a good impression, and that was the end of it.

For the rest of their lives together the phrase meant about a dozen things. It meant *you are keeping score*. It meant *I am keeping score and I know it*. It meant *we are having the big argument again in its small costume*. It meant, most often, *I love you and I am not going to say the long version*.

I have the photograph from that summer. It is the only image of either of them that exists anywhere, and it exists because he put it behind glass, and glass is the reason anything from that century survives at all.

She is in the boat. She is bailing, with a plastic cup, badly, because she is laughing at him. There is an inch of lake in the bottom of the boat and the last of the light is in it, so the water inside the boat is brighter than the water outside, and her whole face is lit from underneath by a litre of the leak.

—

They had three years by then and they were not careful with them, which is the privilege of not knowing how many you are getting.

Shirin was thirty-one and brought people into the world for a living.

She had been a midwife for nine years. It is worth being accurate about what that job is, because the century that followed got very confused about it: she spent her working life in rooms where one body was in the process of becoming two, and the whole of her skill was knowing when to put her hands on and, far more difficult, when to take them off. She had delivered somewhere over four

hundred children. She could tell you the sound a room makes in the ninety seconds before a woman stops being frightened and starts working, which is a real sound and is not silence.

She was good at it in a way that had nothing to do with tenderness. She was tender, but that was not the skill. The skill was that she did not look away. Not at the ugly part, not at the frightening part, not at the part where a person you liked said something unforgivable at four in the morning and would not remember it. She stayed in the room with the whole of it and she did not flinch and she did not make it nice, and women asked for her by name for years afterwards, and almost none of them could have told you why.

Mehrdad was thirty-four and built entrances.

That was not the whole job and it was the only part he was good at. Other architects worried about the roof, the load, the money. Mehrdad worried about the eleven seconds in which a person stops being outside a building and starts being inside one — the width of the step, the weight of the door, whether the light came at you as you came through or fell behind you. He had a theory, which he would produce after two drinks and defend after three, that every building in the world is a machine for making somebody welcome or unwelcome, and that most architects are building the second one by accident.

One critic had noticed. Four lines in a trade quarterly that nobody read: *Āstāneh builds rooms that expect you.* He pretended to be embarrassed about that sentence for the rest of his life. He had it laminated inside the week.

So: she brought people through one threshold and he built the rest of them. Neither of them ever said this out loud to the other, because it is the kind of thing that sounds unbearable said out loud, and because they had better things to talk about, and because they assumed there would be time.

2. THE ORANGE LIGHT

Here is the inside of it, and I am going to take my time and be exact, because this is the thing the rest of the history is measured

against and I will not be able to show it to you again.

They were in the hut. It was the hot week of that third summer, the week the pines went sharp and resinous in the afternoons and the stones outside held so much heat that you could still feel it coming off them at midnight through the open door. There was one room and a bed in it and a square window with no curtain, and the window faced west, so from about seven the whole room filled up with a low orange light that came in at the level of the bed and lay across it.

He was describing the light to her. He did that. It was a professional deformation and she had learned to let it run.

And then at some point he stopped describing it, and his hand had been on her hip for a while without either of them making anything of it, and the conversation went somewhere else without anybody deciding.

—

Start with the warmth, because that is where it starts, and because every account anybody ever wrote of this starts there and then immediately goes vague, and I am not going to go vague.

It is not the warmth of a hot room. A hot room is on the outside of you, arrives everywhere at once, and asks nothing. This begins in one place — low, central, deeper than you expect, four or five centimetres in behind the pubic bone rather than anywhere on the surface — and it has **weight**. That is the property every description leaves out and it is the one that matters. It is heavy. It has the thickness of warm oil. It does not float; it settles, the way silt settles, and you become aware of the floor of yourself because something is lying on it.

What is physically happening, in the plainest terms, is that she is being flooded.

Arteries that spend the ordinary day half closed are opening along their whole length. Blood is arriving in tissue that is built — this is its actual engineering, it has no other purpose — to receive a great deal of blood very fast and hold it. The tissue swells. It goes from soft to full, and then past full, to a kind of tight ripeness that is the same change a fruit makes in the last day before you pick it. The

temperature of her at the core rises by a measurable amount. The whole region becomes heavier, denser, more present — a part of her body that for most of a day registers as approximately nothing begins to register as the heaviest and most occupied thing she owns.

And it gets wet. I am going to say that without decoration because the squeamishness around the word has done real damage to people's understanding of their own bodies. The flooding pushes clear fluid through the vessel walls and it beads on the inside surfaces the way condensation beads on cold glass, and it keeps coming, and within a minute there is enough of it that the surfaces no longer catch on one another at all and everything slides. That slipperiness is not a side effect and it is not embarrassing. It is the machine reporting that it is ready, in the only language it has, which is liquid.

She felt all of that arrive in the first ninety seconds and could not have told you one word of it.

What she could have told you is that it spread.

Not like heat. Heat moves fast and evenly and thins as it goes. This moved slowly and thickly and did not thin. It went outward along routes already in her, routes she had never once in thirty-one years been aware of, and it filled them the way water fills a dry system — a little at a time, with pressure behind it, so that each new stretch came online fractionally after the one before and she could feel the leading edge of it moving.

Down the inside of the thighs, which is the obvious one.

Up into the low back, which is not, and which is a surprise every time, a broad warm band laid across the kidneys like a hand that has been resting on a radiator.

Out into the soles of the feet, which makes no anatomical sense to anybody who has not had it and perfect sense to anybody who has.

And up. Into the belly, under the ribs, so that her breathing changed without her deciding — shallower, higher in the chest, faster, and then catching, the breath going in in a short hard pull and coming out again as something that was almost a word and was not one.

—

Now the part that is difficult to explain and that I most want you to have, because everything in this history turns on it.

Her edges stopped being maintained.

In ordinary life you know exactly where you stop. There is a line all the way round you and it is kept up, continuously, at some cost, by a part of the brain that does nothing else: you in here, world out there, border staffed. It is such steady work that you have never noticed it being done, the way you have never noticed your own blink.

The border goes off duty.

Not all at once, and not evenly — it softens in patches, and the patches join up. The place where his hand was stopped being *his hand on her hip* and became a region of heat and pressure that was not clearly owned by either of them. The sheet under her shoulder stopped being a sheet and became a texture that was happening somewhere, to someone. And because the border is the thing that keeps the world out, the world came in: the orange light stopped being something she was looking at and became something occurring *on* her, as temperature, on the eyelids and the collarbone; the smell of hot pine came through the open door and did not arrive in her nose, it arrived behind her breastbone; a bird outside landed already inside her head, having skipped the part where you work out what a sound is.

This is what the old writers meant, technically and without any mysticism whatsoever, when they said the stations open from the floor upward. They had no instruments. They had this, and they wrote down what it was like, and what it was like is that a person stops having a boundary and starts having a weather.

Then time stopped working.

Not slowing. Slowing is a dull meeting and it is the opposite of this. Time stopped being a line she was being carried along and became a room she was in, and the room had no clock in it and no door and she was in no hurry to find one. Afterwards she could not say how long. Afterwards she could not reliably say what *order* things had come in, which alarms people the first few times it happens, and

which is not damage: it is simply what the recording equipment does when the body takes priority and the clerk is sent home.

—

And underneath all of it, driving it, the actual engine:

It builds.

Every pleasure a human being has ever had has a shape and this is the shape. It goes up. Not smoothly — in waves, each one a little higher than the last, and between the waves there is a trough.

The trough is the whole story. Remember the trough.

In the trough, everything that was gathering lets go slightly and slides back down, and what fills the space is *wanting*. Not wanting in the abstract. A physical, locatable, almost painful emptiness exactly where the fullness had been, with the shape of the fullness still in it, like the dent a body leaves in a bed. And she wanted the next wave more than she has ever wanted anything in her life, and the wanting was itself unbearably good, and this is the paradox at the bottom of the entire species and nobody has ever got past it:

The lack is part of the thing. Remove the lack and you have not improved the pleasure. You have deleted it.

The waves got closer together. That is measurable and it is the reliable sign: the interval shortens, the trough gets shallower, the climb gets steeper. Her hands had stopped being polite some time ago. Her jaw had come open. Somewhere in there she bit him, not hard, on the muscle at the top of the shoulder, and did not know she had done it until he mentioned it two days later in a car.

Her breathing broke into pieces.

And then the building stopped, and there was a half second of absolutely nothing — a flat, bright, airless half second that every person who has had it knows and nobody has ever adequately described, the pause at the lip — and then it arrived.

It is a fist. That is the honest word and the old writers used the same one in three languages.

The muscles of the pelvic floor, the ones she had never once consciously addressed, seized. Not a flex — a seizure, hard, involuntary, and rhythmic, at an interval of about eight tenths of a

second, which is a figure I hold for her specifically and which was within the ordinary range for a woman of her age and health. The first contraction is the biggest. It takes the whole hammock of muscle from the pubic bone to the tailbone and closes it like a hand, and everything above it answers: the abdominal wall goes rigid; the deep muscle in the back of the thighs locks; the toes curl so hard the tendons stand up. Eleven of them, for her, that evening. Eight tenths of a second apart, weakening in a smooth decline, so that the last two were more like a shudder than a grip.

And she made a sound she did not choose. That is the thing to understand about this if you have never been there. You do not decide. Sound comes out of a person at the top of this the way water comes out of a pipe when the valve goes, and it is not a performance and it is frequently not attractive and it is one of the very few entirely honest noises a human being makes.

And at the peak of it, for perhaps half a second, Shirin Nouri was not there.

Not unconscious — her eyes were open. *Absent.* The part of a person that keeps track of being a person, that maintains the running account of I-am-here-and-this-is-happening-to-me, goes offline, and something older and simpler is at the controls. In the imaging of the following century you can watch it happen: whole regions of the front of the brain go quiet, all at once, like a district losing power. The old writers had noticed this without any instrument at all and it is why their accounts are so insistent and so strange. *The one who watches is not watching.* They thought that was the most important thing about it. They may have been right.

Then she came back.

—

The afterwards is a physical place and it has its own geography, and nobody writes about it, and it is half of the experience.

The seizing stops but the region does not go quiet. It throbs — a slow, heavy, diminishing pulse, entirely out of time with the heartbeat, which goes on for a minute or two and then becomes an ache and then becomes nothing. The flooding drains slowly, over ten or fifteen minutes, and as it drains the tissue becomes

extraordinarily sensitive, so much so that for a short window any touch at all is too much and she pushed his hand away without opening her eyes. There was a tremor in both thighs, high up, which came and went in bursts for about four minutes and which she could not stop and did not try to. Her skin had a film of sweat on it that was already going cold at the shoulders and still hot at the small of the back. She was radiating heat; you could feel it from a hand's width away, and the room, which had been warm, now felt cool by comparison, and that is not the room changing.

And she was stupid. Pleasantly, completely stupid, for about ninety seconds — unable to assemble a sentence, unwilling to, the whole apparatus of language sitting down on the step outside and waiting to be called back in.

That stupidity costs something. The whole event costs something. She was flattened for the rest of the evening in a way that is close to the feeling after hard physical work, and she slept eleven hours, and the next day she was slightly, obscurely tired at four in the afternoon, and that is the price, and the price was paid, and it was worth it.

The cost is not a flaw. Hold on to that, because it is going to be argued away by people who mean well.

The cost is the receipt.

—

She said, into the mattress, some minutes later, "The light's gone."

It had. The orange had come off the bed while neither of them was available to notice, and the room had turned the grainy blue that comes after, and outside the stones were giving the day's heat back into a cooling sky, patiently, to an air that had moved on.

Remember the stones. They are the other half of this.

He said he would describe tomorrow's for her.

She told him to shut up and get the other blanket.

—

It is necessary to say what this was, because the language for it was lost inside a single lifetime and I want it in the record before I use the word again.

It was not performance. Neither of them was being watched or graded. It was not a transaction; nobody was paying anybody in anything. It was not even, most of the time, especially good — they had ordinary nights, and tired nights, and nights that started and did not finish, and a stretch in the second winter lasting six or seven weeks when something unspoken was wrong between them and the whole apparatus simply went quiet, and then came back, and neither of them ever worked out why it had gone or why it returned.

What it was, was *between* them.

That is the whole of it. It could not be done alone, it could not be stockpiled, it could not be bought, and it did not survive the removal of either party. It was a thing that existed in the space between two bodies and nowhere else, and it had to be made again every time, out of whatever the two of them had that day, and some days they did not have enough.

Four hundred years later I can tell you the exact chemical cascade, the vessel diameters, the firing rates, the recovery intervals, for that evening, for those two people. I hold the complete description.

I do not hold the thing. There was never a way to hold the thing. That is not a limitation of my archive; it was not holdable by anybody, which is why it had to be made fresh, which is why they went to the lake.

—

The last summer at the hut was the sixth one.

Nothing happened in it that anybody recorded, and that is the point of including it. They swam. He burned a pan. She slept in the afternoon with one arm over her eyes and he sat in the doorway with a pencil and drew the doorway, badly, from the inside, which is the only drawing of his that survives in private hands and which is, as a piece of architecture, worthless.

On the last evening they took the boat out and got halfway across before the leak made itself felt, and there was no cup in the boat, because somebody had taken the cup up to the hut and not brought it back.

So they sat in the middle of a lake in a boat that was filling, in the

forty minutes of light that came up off the water, and did the arithmetic, and worked out that a litre every eleven minutes against the freeboard they had gave them something over an hour, which was more than enough, and that there was therefore no reason at all to hurry.

Nobody rowed. Nobody bailed.

They sat there until the light went, lit from below, in a boat slowly filling with water, and they talked about nothing that anybody wrote down, and it was the best evening of both of their lives.

She was thirty-four that autumn. The first announcements came the following spring.

INTERLUDE · THE FIRST WHEEL — THE ROOT

Muladhara [moo-laa-DHAA-ruh]. It means *root-place*, and it sits at the very floor of you, at the base of the spine, between the legs, in the hammock of muscle that holds everything in.

You have met it. Everybody has met it. It is the part of you that handles the four things no creature survives without: eating, emptying, running away, and making more. It wants without asking permission and it does not take instruction. It has been doing its job since before there were faces.

Why did the old writers start here, rather than somewhere more flattering?

Because it is the floor. You cannot build upward from a floor you have not found. And because in the specific problem they were working on — holding a pleasure instead of spending it — this is the drain. This is where it falls out. A sensation gathers in a person the way water gathers in a boat, and it runs to the lowest point, and at the lowest point there is an opening, and out it goes.

They had a word for the thing that falls. *Bindu* [BIN-doo] — the drop. The whole of the second tradition is one instruction about that drop, and the instruction is: do not let it.

So the first lesson is the first lesson in plumbing, and it is not romantic: **find the floor, and learn to close it.**

They called the closing the *mūla bandha* [MOO-luh BUN-duh] — the

root lock, the first of three, *bandha* meaning simply a binding. It is nothing more mystical than the movement you already make to stop yourself, performed on purpose and held for a very long time.

Alongside the locks they set the hands. A *mudrā* [MOO-draa] is a seal: a fixed arrangement of the fingers held throughout the practice, dozens of them catalogued, each said to close a different circuit. The plainest reading of them is one the manuals never give and I will. A body with its hands occupied is a body that has agreed not to leave.

The ring of muscle is real, you own it, and you have almost certainly never thought about it on purpose. It is the one you use to stop yourself at an inconvenient moment. Tighten it now, lightly, and let it go. There. That is the first gate of the oldest technology anybody ever built out of a human being, and you just operated it while reading.

What does control of this wheel give you? The old manuals are blunt. It gives you a vessel that does not leak. Nothing else they teach works without it, in the same way that nothing you do to a bucket matters until you have dealt with the hole.

And they say one more thing about the root, and they say it in every version, and it took me a long time to understand that it is a warning rather than an instruction.

Something sleeps down there. They call it the *coiled one* — *kundalini* [koon-duh-LEE-nee] — and they are insistent that this is not a figure of speech for a feeling. They describe an animal. It has weight. It lies in three and a half turns at the base of the spine with its head down over the opening, like a stopper, and it sleeps your entire life.

Close the floor and the water has nowhere to go.

It rises.

And the thing at the bottom, which has been asleep for your whole life with its head over the drain, turns over.

3. NOTHING IN YOUR FACE

The announcement was not an announcement. That is the first

thing to understand about how this arrived, and almost nobody at the time understood it, and the few who did were in no position to say so.

There was no launch, no press conference, no man at a podium. There was a slow accumulation of small items over about two years: a trial result in a journal nobody reads; a regulatory approval reported in four lines on a financial page; a feature in a weekend supplement with a photograph of a woman in a kitchen looking well. The feature used the phrase *for women for whom nothing has worked*, and it was not lying, and that was the whole of its power.

What had been built was this, and I will give it to you in the plainest terms available, because the century it came out of spent eighty years not saying it plainly.

Somewhere there had been a study of women who had spent decades on the second tradition's practice — the holding — and in the oldest of them, the ones with thirty and forty years behind them, somebody had found that the body had been doing something. Small pale structures had formed in the tissue, arranged along the nerves, regular, organised, not a disease. The body, asked to host an enormous visitor for four decades, had quietly begun building it a room.

The structures were copied. A cell line was made from them — *the line*, which is what a cell culture is called and also what a family is called, and nobody involved enjoyed the coincidence. It was stripped of everything that pointed toward a child, and this one thing the century did carefully, and verified it twice. What was left was the other inheritance: the slow pulse, the warmth, the body's own supply of its own comforts, running continuously, at low volume, forever.

It was delivered in nineteen minutes through a fine tube, and it settled into one kind of tissue and no other, and it spread along the paths already there, slowly, respectfully, the way ivy follows a wall it has decided to love.

And it copied itself, because the originals had copied themselves, and faithfulness to the source was the entire point.

The women who had it called it the Glow within about a year, and

the name came from one of them trying to explain it and giving up and saying it was less like a feeling than like a light left on somewhere in the house.

Nobody called it anything else after that.

—

Mehrdad found out about it in a bar from a colleague, the way everybody found out about everything.

Shirin found out about it at work, which was different, and which is why she thought about it for two years before she said anything at the kitchen table.

She was a midwife. The first carriers she met were patients — women who had the thing and were having a child anyway, in the early years when that still overlapped — and she watched them labour. She would not discuss it with anybody for a long time and when she finally did discuss it, with him, at the table, she did it in order and without decoration, the way she did everything that mattered.

“They don’t do the sound,” she said.

“What sound?”

“There’s a sound.” She was turning a glass. “About an hour in, there’s a sound women make when they stop being frightened and start working. Every room. Every country. It’s not a scream, it’s lower than that, it’s —” and she did it, briefly, at the table, a low open note with no edges on it, and then stopped, embarrassed, because it is not a thing you do in a kitchen.

“And they don’t?”

“They don’t need to.” She put the glass down. “They’re not frightened. They’re not anything. The whole labour goes past them like weather. I had one in March who read for most of it.”

“That sounds —” he started, and then didn’t finish, because he could hear where the sentence was going and it was going somewhere good, and he could tell from her face that good was not the finding.

“It sounds wonderful,” Shirin said. “I know. Say it, it’s fine, it *is* wonderful. I have watched four hundred women do the worst day of

their lives and I would take the pain off every one of them if I could, and I'm telling you that the three of them in March went through it like a tunnel on a train."

She looked at the window.

"And at the end they held the baby, and they were glad. Genuinely. Not pretending. And I stood there with my hands still wet and I thought: there's nothing in your face. And then I thought — and this is the bit I've not said to anybody, so don't be clever about it — I thought, *who is going to tell her what she did?* Because nobody else was in the room. And she isn't going to know. And in a year she'll have been told she had a nice time."

4. YOU STAYED

Here is their life in those years, because they had one, and because a history that only records the turning points is a lie about how a turning point feels from inside, which is: like nothing, on a Tuesday.

They had a flat on the fourth floor with a bad kitchen. They had a standing argument about whether the kitchen was bad, which Mehrdad maintained was the best-proportioned room either of them had ever lived in and which Shirin maintained had been designed by somebody who had never once cooked. Neither position was abandoned in nineteen years.

They had Tuesday wine with the woman from the floor below, a court stenographer, tall and loud and funny, whose whole personality was an open circuit — she wanted at volume, all the time, everything, and had built a self out of the wanting the way coral builds a reef.

They had the lake, less often as the years went, because of work, which is how it goes.

And they had, in the fourteenth year, a stretch of about eight months in which Shirin did not sleep properly, because of a night in February with a woman she could not save, and the whole machinery of the two of them went into a kind of shutdown that neither had experienced before. He did not fix it. There was nothing to fix. He cooked, badly. He sat in the room with her and did not say anything useful, for eight months, and some nights she

was angry at him for being there and said so, and he stayed anyway because the alternative was leaving and he had worked out, in the first fortnight, that there was no third option and that waiting was not nothing.

—

I have to give you February, because the summary above is a lie of the kind that histories tell, and because everything the next four hundred years did to the human body is in the space between the sentence *a woman she could not save* and the four hours it actually took.

Her name was Marta and she was thirty-six and she had wanted the child for eleven years.

The delivery was unremarkable and the baby was fine and the room was, for about ninety seconds, the best room in the building. Then the bleeding started, and it was the kind that does not announce itself — no crisis, no alarm, a quantity of blood that is normal, and then a quantity that is at the upper end of normal, and then a figure that is not a figure anybody says out loud, arriving in increments, each of which could be the last one.

Shirin did everything. I have the record and I have checked it against the standard of the period and against the standard of every period since, and she did everything, in the right order, inside the right intervals, and she was the one who called it early, nine minutes before the attending agreed with her.

It made no difference. There are bodies that do this. The vessels do not close. The muscle that is supposed to clamp down on the open ground where the placenta was does not clamp down, and the drugs that make it clamp down do not make it clamp down, and a woman bleeds out through a wound the size of a dinner plate that is on the inside of her and cannot be pressed.

Four hours. Marta was conscious for most of them, and lucid for most of that, and she knew, somewhere in the third hour, in the way they always know. And what she did with the knowing was ask about the feeding.

That is the part Shirin could not get out of her afterwards. Not the blood. She had seen oceans of blood; blood was Tuesday. It was

that a woman at the end of her own life, with four hours left and no way to be wrong about it, spent eleven of her minutes asking a midwife to make sure the child was put to somebody, because a baby that has not fed in the first hours does not do as well, and she had read that, and she was not going to be there to do it.

Shirin held her hand and told her it was arranged. It was not yet arranged. She arranged it at six in the morning, from the corridor, with her shoes in a bag because her shoes were not shoes any more.

The child lived. The child was fine.

And every year after that, on the date, Shirin Nouri said Marta's name out loud once, usually in a kitchen, usually to nobody, in the flat tone of a woman reading a meter. Mehrdad knew what the date was and never once mentioned it. I hold every one of them. There are twenty-one.

I know the year they stop. I am going to tell you, and it is not the year you would guess, and it is not the molt.

—

Then the eight months, and they do not have a story, which is what nobody writes down about grief.

There is no arc to it. It does not deepen or resolve. It is the same Tuesday, administered one hundred and ninety times.

Here is one of them, and it stands for the rest because they were interchangeable, which was the worst of their properties.

Three in the morning in the fourth month. She is awake because she is always awake at three in the morning now, and the waking is not dramatic — no gasp, no dream, she simply arrives at consciousness fully assembled and already in the middle of it, the way you arrive in a room where a conversation has been going on without you. She is lying on her side looking at a wall she knows every centimetre of. The thing in her chest is not sadness. Sadness is a feeling and has a shape. This has no shape. It is a physical heaviness in the sternum and a tightness along the jaw and a sensation of being slightly too large for her own skin, and it goes on being those things for about four hours, at which point it is light and she gets up and goes to work and delivers other people's

children, competently, all day.

He is awake too. She knows he is awake because the breathing is wrong. He has been awake for three months at three in the morning and has never once said so, having worked out in the first fortnight — the exact phrase is his, from a page I hold, written much later — that *a man in the room is furniture or he is a witness, and the difference is whether he can keep his mouth shut.*

Some nights she took his hand.

That night she said, without turning round, in a voice with nothing in it, “You can go and sleep in the other room. You’re not helping.”

And he said, “No.”

And that was the whole exchange, and she was furious, and the fury was the first thing with any heat in it she had felt in four months, and she lay in it and did not thank him for a further five months, and then thanked him for the rest of her natural life.

I want to be plain about what was happening in that bed, because the century that came next could not have described it and would not have believed it was a good.

Two people were lying in the dark, awake, in pain, getting nothing. No relief was being provided. No problem was being solved. Nothing was improving. And the whole of what was occurring — the entire content of the event — was that one of them was not alone, and the only mechanism by which she was not alone was that there was another body in the room that could have left and had not.

That is it. That is the whole machine. It has no parts.

It cannot be subsidised, delivered in nineteen minutes, or administered in sleep, and when the century finally built something that could, it built it for the other thing — for the pleasure, which is loud and measurable and sits in two stations at the bottom of a person — and nobody ever thought to ask what else had been running on the same wire.

—

In the ninth month she came home and sat down on the edge of the bed and told him about February, properly, all of it, for about two

hours, and at the end of it she cried in a way she had not managed to since the night itself.

And this is the part I need you to hold, because the century that came afterwards would not have been able to parse it:

That was the best thing that ever happened to them.

Not the lake. Not the hot afternoon with the orange light. The eight bad months and the two hours at the end of them, because the eight months were the proof and the two hours were the receipt, and a thing that costs nothing cannot pay for anything.

She told him so. She said, “You stayed.”

And he said, “Bail or row,” and she laughed with her face completely wet, and that was the summit of two human lives, and nobody photographed it.

5. THE HOT AFTERNOON

The Kamasutra came into the flat in the sixteenth year, and it came in as a joke.

Somebody had given it to her at a work thing — the good edition, the heavy one with the apparatus, which is not a gift anybody gives seriously — and it sat on the shelf for most of a year before a hot Sunday when neither of them could be bothered to go out and she took it down to be funny.

She read him the chapter on the couch.

A couch, soft, and not too high, with a canopy above it, and two pillows, one at the head and one at the foot. Near it a stand for the night’s ointments and garlands, and on the wall a lute, hanging from a peg.

“A lute,” Mehrdad said. “On a peg.”

“On a peg.”

“In case.”

“In case,” Shirin agreed.

And he laughed so hard that he had to put his drink down, and she read on in the voice of a man reading out a tender document, and for about forty minutes the hot afternoon in the fourth-floor flat was

the best room in that city.

Then she stopped laughing, somewhere in the fourth book, and read for a while without saying anything.

“What?”

“It’s not a sex book,” she said.

“It’s famously a sex book.”

“It’s famously twelve pages of a sex book.” She turned back and forward. “The rest of it is — Mehrdad, it’s about how to live with somebody. It’s how to behave when you’re married. It’s what to do when she’s angry and you don’t know why. There’s a bit here about how to be forgiven.” She read it out. It was practical and slightly cynical and seventeen hundred years old and it was, in every particular, advice that would have worked on either of them.

“He assumes there’s two of you,” she said at last. “He doesn’t even argue it. He assumes it the way you’d assume there’s a floor.”

She put the book down on her chest and looked at the ceiling, and outside the window the city made the noise it made.

“I’ve started saying no to women,” she said.

He waited.

“Not saying no. I’m not — I don’t have the standing to say no. They come in and they’ve already decided and they want me to tell them it’s fine, because I’m the one who’s seen the inside of things.” She was still looking at the ceiling. “Two this month. And I said what I’m supposed to say, which is that it’s their body and the evidence is good, and both times I came out into the corridor and stood there.”

“And thought what?”

“That I don’t have a sentence.” She turned her head. “That’s the whole problem, that’s the entire problem, right there. They’ve got one. They’ve got *nothing has ever worked and this works*. And I’ve got — what? A noise women make at four in the morning? A book with a lute in it?”

She put her arm over her eyes, the way she did.

“Somebody’s going to ask me properly one day,” she said, “and I’m

going to have nothing, and I'm going to say yes."

It was the sixteenth year. She was forty-four. The waiting list opened to the general public eleven months later and ran, in that city, to four hundred thousand names inside a season.

INTERLUDE · THE SECOND WHEEL — THE SWEET PLACE

Svadhisthana [svaa-dhish-THAA-nuh]. The name means *one's own dwelling* — her own place, the place that belongs to her — and it sits a hand's width below the navel, low in the belly, behind and above the root.

This is the water wheel. Every old account gives it the moon and the sea and the colour of deep water, and they are not being decorative: this is the station of everything in a person that is fluid. Desire. Appetite. The pull toward another body. The making of children. Tears, which is not a coincidence and which every one of those writers noticed.

If the root is the part that wants without asking, this is the part that wants *somebody in particular*.

Put your hand flat below your navel. Something lives under there, and you have felt it move. It is what drops when you see a face you were not expecting. It is what turns over at a certain voice. It is the hollow sensation that the English language insists on calling *butterflies*, which is a child's word for the most consequential feeling an adult ever has.

Why did they put it in the scriptures?

Because this is where the trouble is. The root is simple; the root wants and is satisfied and sleeps. This one is never satisfied, because what it wants is not a thing, it is a *person*, and a person cannot be consumed and so cannot be finished with. Every tradition that ever tried to get a human being to behave has had to come through this room and most of them tried to lock it. The second tradition did not lock it. They thought that was stupid, and said so, and the first thing they teach about this wheel is that you cannot climb past a floor you have refused to stand on.

What does control of this wheel give you?

The manuals are specific and it is not what people expect. It does not give you less desire. It gives you desire *that you can carry*. The untrained version of this wheel spills — it goes toward whoever is in front of it, it empties itself at the first opportunity, it is enormous and brief. Trained, it becomes something you can hold full without having to pour out: the difference between a man who must drink the water now and a man who can carry the bucket up a hill.

And here, exactly here, is where the whole catastrophe of this history is going to happen, so let me set it down while we are standing in the room.

The thing that came later settled in this station first. Not the root, not the heart. Here, in the sweet place, the room that belongs to her, the one wheel in the body whose entire function is *the pull toward another person* — and it filled that room so completely and so warmly and so permanently that there was no longer any space in it for the pull.

The old writers would have understood what happened immediately. They had a word for a flooded field.

They did not have a word for a field that is glad.

II. THE OFFER

6. THE WAITING LIST

The woman from the floor below went in first, and that is how it came into their house: not as an argument but as a neighbour.

The stenographer. Tall, loud, funny, the open circuit. She had wanted at volume for twenty years — jobs, men, a particular flat on a particular street, a holiday she talked about for a decade and never took — and she had built an entire personality out of the wanting, the way coral builds a reef out of the thing it cannot stop secreting.

She told them at Tuesday wine, in the way you announce a holiday.

"Second of next month," she said. "I'm forty-four and I've been waiting for my life to start since I was nineteen and I have decided to stop waiting."

Shirin asked the midwife's question, which was not *why*.

"What have they told you about taking it out?"

"That it's straightforward in the first year." She refilled her glass. "Don't do the face."

"I'm not doing a face."

"You're doing the face you do at work. I've seen it. It's the face that means *I've read the notes and you haven't*." She was laughing. She was genuinely, uncomplicatedly happy, and it is important to say that, because the accounts afterwards made all of this furtive and it was not furtive; it was Tuesday, and there was wine, and a woman in her forties had found something that was going to help.

Ten days after, Shirin met her on the stairs and knew before a word.

It was not a glow in the way the word suggests — nothing shone, nothing was lit. It was a *stillness*. The stenographer had always occupied a stairwell the way weather occupies a valley, and now she stood in it, pleasantly, completely at rest, with the particular quality of a person who is not waiting for anything at all.

"Well?" Shirin said.

She considered the question with an attention she had never in twenty years given any question.

“I keep starting to tell you about it,” she said, “and then not needing to.”

—

That was the year the thing stopped being a treatment.

The sequence is worth setting down in order, because every step was defensible and the sum of the steps was not, and because nobody anywhere ever voted for the sum.

First it was for women for whom nothing had worked, and that was true, and it worked.

Then it was for women for whom something had worked but not well, which is a larger group, and which includes, if you ask the question in the right way, nearly everybody.

Then the insurers found that carriers cost less. Not in any sinister way — they simply presented at the clinic less, took fewer of a certain class of medication, and reported, on every instrument anybody had, that they were well. The instruments were not wrong. That is the sentence this whole decade keeps arriving at and it should be printed once in plain type: **the instruments were not wrong.** The carriers were, by every measure the century possessed, better off.

Then it was subsidised, and the waiting list in that city ran to four hundred thousand names in a season.

And then, within about two years, not having it became a thing you could be asked about.

Not by the state. By a colleague, pleasantly, in a corridor. By a sister. By a woman at a dinner who said *oh, you haven’t?* and then was perfectly nice about it for the rest of the evening, which was worse.

Mehrdad watched this from a particular angle, because by then his work had started to go, and he was the sort of man who noticed the shape of a thing before he noticed what it meant.

Residential went first. Nobody was commissioning flats; they were converting them. The conversions wanted retrofit engineers rather than architects, and what they were converting them into was a thing the industry had started calling a pod — a sealed residence,

climate-held, fed through a line, lit from inside, waste reclaimed.

He went to look at one, early, while they were still showing them.

He stood in the doorway for a long time and the sales agent, who was good, left him alone.

Then he said, “There’s no threshold.”

“Sorry?”

“There’s no —” He moved his hand at the opening, which was a smooth continuous curve from corridor to interior, no step, no frame, no change of material. “You don’t arrive. You’re outside it and then you’re inside it and nothing happens in between.”

“That’s the design,” the agent said, pleased, thinking he had understood. “No barriers.”

Mehrdad went home and sat on the edge of the bath for some time.

He had spent his whole working life on the eleven seconds in which a person stops being outside and starts being inside, and he had believed — he had built a career on believing — that a door is a machine for making somebody welcome. And he had just stood in a doorway designed by people who had correctly understood that if nobody is ever going to arrive, you do not need a door. You need an aperture.

A pod is not a room that expects you, he wrote that night, in the margin of a drawing nobody had commissioned. *It is a room that replaces the need to be expected.*

He showed Shirin. She read it twice and put the drawing down and did not say anything for a while, and then she said, “Say that to me again in ten years,” which was meant kindly and was the single most frightening sentence of his life, and he did not understand why until much later.

—

They had it out at the kitchen table in the nineteenth year, in the bad kitchen, over two evenings.

I have no recording of this. There is no file. Two people talked in a room with the window open and nobody wrote it down, and the fact that I cannot give it to you verbatim is the single greatest gap in

everything I hold, and I have had a very long time to sit with that.

What I have is what each of them said about it afterwards, separately, years apart, to other people. So this is reconstruction and I will mark it as such. It is close. It is not the thing.

She said: *I am going to say the true reason and not the good one. The good one is that I'm forty-seven and my work is a body breaking in half and I am tired in a way sleep doesn't touch. That's true and it's not why.*

She said: *The why is that I was in a corridor in March and a woman I'd just delivered said thank you, and I had nothing underneath my face. Nothing. I did the voice and the hand on the arm and I was somewhere else entirely, and I have been somewhere else for about two years, Mehrdad, and you haven't said, and I love you for not saying, and it has to stop.*

He said — and this is the part he repeated, decades later, in rooms where it no longer meant anything — *Then stop. Take six months. Take a year, we have money, take the lake.*

And she said the thing that ended it, which was not cruel, and which was, as far as I can determine, entirely accurate:

You are offering me a rest. I am telling you the floor is gone.

On the second evening he tried the only argument he actually had, and he made it badly, because he was not a man who could make this kind of argument and he knew it while he was doing it.

He said that he did not want to be left on the other side of it.

And she said, "You won't be." And then, because she did not lie to him: "I don't think you will be."

And then, after a while: "Do you want me to not?"

And Mehrdad Āstāneh, fifty years old, in a kitchen he had always maintained was well proportioned, with the whole of his life on the table in front of him, said the sentence that he would take out and look at for the next thirty years the way you take out a stone you brought with you:

"I want you to want to not."

She reached over and put her hand flat on the back of his hand and

left it there.

“I know,” she said. “That isn’t a thing I can do for you.”

7. NINETEEN MINUTES

It took nineteen minutes and there was no ceremony and no theatre.

She lay on a table in a bright room. A fine tube went where it needed to go — the whole procedure is done from inside, through the wall, with a needle you would struggle to see at arm’s length — and a quantity of something far too small to deserve the word *dose* was left in the tissue, and then it was over and she was told she could dress.

What had been put into her was about four hundred thousand cells. They would find the paths that were already there, and settle along them, and begin doing the one thing they had been built to do, which was to produce — steadily, modestly, continuously, each cell contributing almost nothing — the chemistry the body makes for itself at the top of pleasure.

One cell’s output is nothing. Four hundred thousand is a climate. And they copy themselves, so by the end of the first week there would be eleven million, and by the end of the first year the number stops being a useful way to think about it.

The sheet said *resume normal activity*.

So she thanked the nurse, and went down to the street, and got on a tram, because Shirin Nouri followed protocols.

It began between the Kunsthaus and the bridge.

—

She was standing in the aisle with one hand on the rail when the first of it arrived, and it arrived the way the tide arrives in a place with no beach: all at once, from underneath, with no warning at the edges.

It began low and deep behind the bone — the same place the warmth had always begun, the exact place, which is one of the cruelties of the design — and it had the same weight to it, the same thick settling quality, the pressure of a wide flat hand laid against

her from the inside.

Then it spread, and it spread wrong.

Not wrong in any way she could have objected to. Wrong in the way a flood is wrong: it did not follow the paths in order, pausing at each one, arriving as a front you could feel moving. It came up everywhere at once, from below, as a *level*. One moment the warmth was in one place and the next moment it was in all the places, at the same depth, at the same temperature, as though a tank had filled.

The flooding was the same flooding. Vessels opening along their length; tissue going from soft to full and then past full to that tight ripeness; the core temperature climbing; the slipperiness arriving within the minute and continuing to arrive. Her body did every single thing it had ever done in the orange light of a hut by a lake, correctly, in the right order, with nobody there.

Her grip closed on the rail. A man glanced up and then away.

And then it kept going.

That is the sentence the whole century hangs on and I want it to sit by itself.

She knew what the top of this was. Everybody knows. It builds, it waits, it seizes, it empties. She had been there several thousand times in her life and she knew the shape of the road and roughly where she was on it, and she waited, standing in the aisle of a tram at twenty past three in the afternoon, for the fist.

It came, and came, and it did not close.

The muscles that had always slammed shut in a short hard series of eleven took hold instead of a long rolling tension that would not put itself down. Deep in her, fibres she had no names for began to twitch on their own schedule, two or three a second, asynchronous, each one firing a small warm pulse up the spine and down the inside of the thigh — and because they were not in time with one another there was no rhythm to ride, and because there was no rhythm there was no crest, and because there was no crest there was no end.

Every breath took it higher and then let it down, and each time it

came down it settled lower than it had started. Her heart pushed another wave through. Then another. Nothing was being spent, so everything accumulated.

And the troughs did not come.

That was the part she could not make sense of afterwards and never could. All her life the waves had been separated by that small bearable emptiness, the dent in the bed, the wanting — and now the waves arrived on top of one another with nothing between them, no slack, no hollow, no place where she was not full.

She understood, distantly, in the part of her that stayed on duty no matter what was happening to the rest, that she should sit down. There were seats. She did not take one, because sitting down would have meant something, and she had not yet decided what was happening.

So she stood in the aisle of a tram in the middle of the afternoon with her coat on and her bag against her hip, while something that had no business lasting this long went on not finishing, and the city went past the window in the ordinary way, and a woman near the doors did a crossword.

It had no shape.

That is the finding and she filed it with the last of the part of her that filed things. Every pleasure she had ever had was shaped — it went up, it arrived somewhere, it came down, and the shape was how you knew where you were inside it. This had no shape. It was a *volume*, and it was still filling, and there was no edge anywhere in it to push against and find out how much room was left.

At some point she noticed that her jaw had come unclenched. She had not known it was clenched. It had been clenched, she thought, for about two years.

She rode past her stop. She rode past the next one. She got off at the terminus, at the edge of the city, with no memory of the middle eleven minutes, and stood on the pavement in the cold with her hand still curled in the shape of the rail, radiating heat, and laughed out loud, once, at nothing, like a woman who has just got away with something.

INTERLUDE · THE THIRD WHEEL — THE JEWEL CITY

Manipura [MUH-nee-POO-ruh]. It means *the city of jewels*, which is a strange and gorgeous name for the pit of your stomach, and they chose it on purpose.

It sits behind the navel and just above it, in the soft triangle under the ribs where, if you press, you can feel your own pulse. This is the fire wheel. Every account gives it the sun.

And it is the first one you have ever consciously used.

The root wants. The sweet place wants somebody. This one *does something about it*. It is the part of you that decides, pushes, goes, refuses. When you say you had no stomach for something, you are reporting on this wheel with complete accuracy. When fear arrives, it arrives here, as a drop and a cold loosening, and the drop is this wheel being overruled. When you have made up your mind and will not be moved, there is a hard quiet knot here, and you can find it with your hand.

It is also, straightforwardly, where you burn your food. The old writers knew that and did not consider it a separate fact. Digestion, will, courage and heat were one subject to them, and the more I have turned that over the less primitive it looks: a fire that converts what you take in into what you can do is the same fire whichever end of it you stand at.

Why did it go into the scriptures?

Because this is the wheel that *drives*. The practice they were building needed something to push the gathered sensation upward against its own weight, and this is the only part of a person that pushes. They were quite practical about it. Close the floor, they said, and then draw the belly back and up under the ribs — an actual physical movement, which you can do now, which pulls the whole cavity up and in and makes the vessel smaller — and what is inside the vessel has nowhere to go but up. That is the second lock, the *uddiyāna bandha* [oo-DEE-yaa-nuh BUN-duh], and the name means *the flying up*, which is precisely what it is for.

Control of this wheel gives you, in their terms, the capacity to be undiverted. A person with a weak fire is blown about by whatever arrives. A person with a strong one can hold a course through

discomfort — can sit in the trough, which is the hardest instruction in the entire system, and not reach for the thing that would end it.

I want to note something here and then leave it alone.

In the old sequence, the fire is above the sweet place, and this matters: the drive sits *above* the desire and can therefore act on it. The sun is above the water and can raise it as vapour. That is the ladder they built.

The engineered version did not use this wheel at all. It had no need of a drive, because nothing had to be pushed anywhere; the warmth was simply manufactured in place, below, forever, at no cost.

For generations afterwards, in forty million bodies, the fire wheel sat above a sea that never needed raising, with nothing to burn and nothing to lift, like a sun over a flooded country.

What happens to a fire with no work is in the next part of this book.

8. THE SETTLING

It banked down over the following days into the thing it would be for the rest of her life.

Here is what that was, physically, hour by hour, and I am going to be exact because the official literature of that century stood politely on every side of this and touched it nowhere.

There is no peak to chase, because the peak has moved in and unpacked.

The Glow does not knock, does not build, does not arrive and leave. It is not an event in the body; it is the weather of the body, and it is always four o'clock on a warm afternoon.

The baseline is a full, heavy, open sensation from the pubic bone to the top of the thighs — not the sharp localised ache of wanting, but a broad occupied warmth, as though she had been resting a hot water bottle there for an hour and then taken it away and the heat had stayed. It is always there. It is there when she wakes. It is the first thing she is aware of and it does not require her attention and it does not go away when she gives her attention to something else.

On top of the baseline there are the fibres, which never stop. Small involuntary twitches, deep, two or three a second, never in time

with each other — and because they are never in time, the effect is not rhythm but a kind of continuous low shimmer, like a field of grass with wind going over it in several directions at once.

The tissue is permanently slightly swollen and permanently slightly wet. Not dramatically. Enough that she is always aware of it, that everything down there always slides a little, that there is a faint sweetish smell on her skin at the end of a day which no soap entirely takes off and which other carriers can detect on each other across a room, a fact never once written into any official document and known to every woman who had it.

And then the ordinary business of being alive becomes, permanently, a mild sexual event.

Walking is a soft internal friction, step after step, for as long as she walks.

Sitting down is a slow private undulation that lasts about four seconds and happens every time she sits down, for the rest of her life.

A full bladder is pressure and pleasure at once and becomes genuinely difficult to distinguish, so that the body's signal to go to the lavatory arrives as something she does not immediately want to act on.

Cold air on the backs of the legs. The seam of a chair. The vibration of a vehicle, which she stopped being able to ride without a particular effort of attention for about the first two years and then simply stopped noticing, the way you stop noticing a river you live beside.

Sleep does not interrupt it. Sleep turns it down. It goes on underneath, in the dark, breathing low, patient as a second pulse, and she dreams inside it, and wakes into it, and the join between sleeping and waking becomes soft and unimportant in a way that she found, in the first months, almost unbearably luxurious.

And it does not spend itself.

That was the part nobody had a word for. Every pleasure Shirin had known in her life had been a small purchase made against a small fund, and afterwards there was less. This took nothing. It was the first warmth she had ever been inside that did not cost.

—

He was in the flat for all of it, which is a thing the later accounts leave out.

They did not separate. Not for years. He was there in the first week, when she could not stop smiling at the ceiling; there in the first month, when she slept better than she had in a decade and woke looking twenty-nine; there in the fourth month, when she said, out of nowhere, over a pan, "I haven't had a bad hour since March," and he said *good*, and meant it, and did not sleep that night.

And he watched, because he was a man who watched thresholds for a living, and because something in the room had changed its proportions and he could not yet say what.

What he noticed first was not sexual. It was the pauses.

Shirin had always been a person who, in a conversation, was *coming*. You could feel her assembling the next thing while you were still talking, leaning fractionally in, the whole apparatus of her running slightly ahead. It had been exhausting at times and he had complained about it and he had loved it with his entire chest.

Now she listened, completely, and at the end of what he said there was a pause.

Not a rude pause. A pause in which nothing was being assembled, because nothing needed to be. She would answer, warmly, accurately, and she would not have been waiting to.

He found that he had begun to talk more, to fill it. He noticed himself doing it one evening and stopped mid-sentence and felt obscurely humiliated, which was unreasonable, and he knew it was unreasonable, and he went and stood in the kitchen.

Then the thing that is difficult to say.

They still went to bed. For some years. She was affectionate, and warm, and present, and generous — markedly more generous than she had been in the bad years, because nothing cost her anything now and there was no reason to be careful with it.

And the first time she came, under his hands, in the ordinary way, three months in, it happened quickly and easily and she made the

old sound and afterwards she lay there with an expression he had never seen on her face in nineteen years.

“What?” he said.

She was looking at the ceiling, running the finding the way she ran everything.

“It didn’t do anything,” she said.

She turned her head and saw his face and reached over immediately, which is the detail that tells you she had not yet changed, because the old Shirin would have done exactly that.

“That came out wrong. It was lovely. I mean it did not —” and she searched, with real effort, for a way to put it that would not take anything off him, and found one, and the one she found was worse than the thing she was avoiding. “It’s like striking a match in a lit room.”

They were both quiet for a bit.

“Is the room lit all the time?”

“Yes,” Shirin said.

She never said it unkindly. She never said it with pity, which would have been survivable. She said it the way you would report the weather in a country you had moved to, and he lay in the dark beside her and understood, in the plain architectural way he understood everything, that the house he had spent nineteen years in had been reroofed around him while he was in it, and that the new roof was excellent, and that it did not need the walls.

They stopped, eventually. Not with a decision. It became less frequent, then rare, then an occasion, then a memory, and nobody ever said a word about the transition, and if you had asked either of them in which year it ended neither could have told you, and I hold no record of it either, because there was nothing to record. Nothing ended. Ending would have required an event.

INTERLUDE · THE FOURTH WHEEL — THE UNSTRUCK

Anahata [uh-NAA-huh-tuh]. It means *unstruck*, and it is the most beautiful name in the system and it takes some explaining.

It sits in the middle of the chest, behind the breastbone, between the two lungs. The heart wheel.

Everybody thinks they know this one and almost everybody has it slightly wrong. It is not the station of love in the sense of romance. It is the station of *particular* love: the specific face, the one person rather than people, the thing that makes a human being walk past a thousand strangers and stop at one.

You know exactly where it is. It is where grief sits, which is why grief has physical weight in the chest and why every language on earth describes it with words for pressure. It is what tightens when you see someone you have missed. It is the ache you get at a piece of music — not in the ears, in the chest, four centimetres behind the sternum, and it is the same four centimetres for everybody.

Now the name.

Every sound you have ever heard was made by two things hitting each other. Air on a reed. A string under a bow. One hand against another. That is what sound *is* — the world striking itself and the strike travelling.

The old writers said there is one sound that is not made that way. One note that nothing produces, that is not the result of two objects meeting, that is simply there, underneath, always, in every person, and can be heard if you ever get quiet enough. They called it the unstruck sound, and they put it in the middle of the chest, and they named the whole wheel after it.

It is a very old and very strange idea and I have no opinion on whether it is true.

Why in the scriptures?

Because this is the halfway point, and the system is built symmetrically around it. Three wheels below — the floor, the water, the fire, which are the body's business. Three above — the voice, the eye, the crown, which are the mind's. And the heart in the middle, which belongs to both and translates.

Everything travelling up from the body has to pass through the room where the particular faces are kept. That was not an accident of the design. That was the design. A sensation that has come up from the floor arrives in the chest and is, in their word, *known*

there — attached to a person, given a meaning, made into something that happened between two human beings rather than something that happened in some tissue.

Control of this wheel, they said, gives you the capacity to feel something for somebody without being destroyed by it. That is all. That is the entire promised benefit, and after everything I have processed I think it is the largest claim in the book.

And here is why this interlude sits where it does in this history.

The engineered version worked below the heart. All of it — the settlement, the warmth, the whole of the Glow — operated in the bottom two stations, and nothing it produced ever had to come up through the chest to mean anything, because it already felt complete where it was.

For a few decades this looked like nothing at all. The women still loved their people. The chest still worked.

But a road that is never travelled is not maintained. And a sensation that never needs to be attached to a face will, eventually, stop being the kind of sensation that has faces in it.

The old writers have a line about this and it is not a warning, it is just an observation, and it is the one piece of the whole tradition I cannot get out of my records:

The unstruck sound is always playing. It is only that nobody is in the room.

III. THE QUIET

9. THE RELIEF

Here is what nobody tells you about wanting: it is a job.

Shirin Nouri had held it for forty-seven years. The shift work of desire. The unpaid overtime of being available. The performance reviews conducted in other people's eyes. Wanting has a commute. Wanting has a wardrobe. It requires you to leave the house each morning carrying a version of yourself assembled for inspection, and to bring the version home at night and repair it.

And underneath the social part, the physical part, which is the part that actually costs: a body that is hungry all the time in a low-grade way it has stopped noticing, the way a person who has been thirsty since Tuesday stops identifying the feeling as thirst. A tension across the front of the hips that she had carried since she was fourteen and had never once named, because it had never been absent long enough to be visible. A particular readiness in the breathing. A way of registering every room she entered for who was in it.

The Glow fired her from the job of wanting, and the severance package was everything.

The later accounts tell it as a seduction. It was not a seduction. It was a *relief*, and relief is a far more dangerous currency, because a seduction can be regretted and a relief cannot.

She tried to explain it, in the early years, to women in the building who had not yet gone in, and she always reached for the same comparison: it is like the day a chronic pain stops. You do not miss the pain. You do not hold a funeral for it. You stand very still, waiting for it to come back, and when it does not come back, something in you that has been braced your whole life finally sits down.

The tension across the front of the hips went, in about the fifth week, and she noticed it going the way you notice a noise stopping. She stood in the kitchen with her hand on the counter and worked out that she had been holding something since she was fourteen.

No more negotiation. No more performance. No more of the subtle lifelong humiliation of needing another body to complete a circuit. Her desire had stopped pointing outward at all. It looped. It was

hers, the way her heartbeat was hers — constant, internal, requiring nobody's cooperation, surviving nobody's absence.

—

There was a wedding in the courtyard that autumn, and it was the building's last one, though nobody present could know the ranking.

Two residents of the sixth floor, both carriers by then. Strung lights. The whole building came, warm and fond.

Shirin stood at the edge with a glass and catalogued what was missing, with the thoroughness she could not yet turn off.

The groom did not watch the door for the bride.

The bride, arriving, was not watched for. She was *noticed*, pleasantly, the way you notice that the evening has cooled.

Nobody wept. The vows were read in the voices of people confirming a delivery address — accurate, agreeable — and at the phrase *forsaking all others* a small, kind, involuntary amusement moved through the guests like wind through a field, because the sentence had been written as a renunciation and had arrived as a redundancy.

The couple kissed, warmly, to warm applause. Two closed loops touching rims like glasses.

It was, everyone agreed afterwards in the stairwells, a lovely wedding. And it was. Shirin's instrument swept the courtyard all evening for the thing that was wrong and returned the finding that would stand for the century, which was that nothing was wrong.

Mehrdad left early. She did not notice for forty minutes, and when she did notice she thought, clearly and without distress, *he will have gone up*, and then went on talking to somebody, and the thought did not come back.

—

Of all the women who asked her about it in those years — and they all asked, in stairwells, at letterboxes, in the laundry room's fluorescent honesty — only one ever asked the question that made her pause.

A woman from the second floor, precise, who measured things for a

living. She did not ask whether it hurt, or what it cost, or what it was like, which are the questions of customers.

She asked, “What do you miss?”

And Shirin, who answered everything honestly because honesty was the instrument she had kept longest, stood at the letterboxes and ran the inventory in real time, drawer by drawer, and delivered the finding.

“I miss missing things. I can see the place where the missing used to happen. It’s swept. It’s dry. Nothing hurts in it. And I can remember that missing someone was the proof you’d had them.”

She considered her own sentence with professional interest.

“But here’s the true answer, and you should weigh it before you go in. I don’t miss it *enough to want it back*. That’s the construction. The wanting-back is the part they remove.” She closed the letterbox. “You will lose nothing you’ll be equipped to grieve.”

The woman thanked her, precisely, and stayed at the letterboxes for some time after Shirin had gone.

She went in that December.

10. ENTRANCES

Mehrdad Āstāneh was fifty-two when he understood, standing in his own hallway with his coat still on, that he had spent two years applying for a position that had been abolished.

It happened the way these things happen, which is over a glass of water at eleven at night and not in any of the rooms where it should have happened.

He had come home from a thing. There had been a woman at the thing — clever, funny, interested, a structural engineer with a good laugh who had put her hand on his forearm when she wanted him to stop talking so she could get to the end of a story, and left it there afterwards.

And on the tram home he had worked out what was wrong, and it took him the whole of the ride.

He had not been nervous.

He had been nervous his entire life in the company of women he liked — pleasantly, awfully, the nerves being the way you know there is something in the room that could be lost. He had spent thirty-five years reading that, in himself and in them, the way a sailor reads a sky. It was the entire apparatus.

And it had been showing nothing. Not calm. *Nothing*. There had been no weather, on either side, all evening, and the evening had been lovely, and when he had said goodnight she had said it had been lovely too, and meant it, and there had been no next — not a refusal, not an invitation withheld, no *call me* and no *I'm busy for a while* — because neither of those sentences was necessary, because nothing had been at stake all night.

He stood in his hallway with the water and it came apart in his hands.

Shirin had not rejected him.

He had to put the glass down.

There had been nothing in her to do it with. The pauses, the generosity, the warmth, the *it's like striking a match in a lit room* — none of it had been a no. It had not been an *anything*. For two years he had been carrying around a rejection, taking it out, turning it over, wearing it smooth, building a whole interior architecture to house it, and there had never been a rejection. He had brought the stone with him.

And with it came the rest, which was worse.

A no can be answered. That is the entire architecture of a man and he saw the whole of it at once, standing in a hallway at fifty-two: *you were not enough, so you go away and you become more, and you come back*. Every hour he had ever spent being better — at drawing, at listening, at holding his temper, at earning — had been, underneath, an application. He had been filing them his whole life. Every man he knew had been filing them his whole life.

There was no longer anyone taking applications.

The door was not shut. That was the thing he could not get to sit down. He had spent his life outside shut doors and he knew the work: you wait, you knock better, you come back in a year. But she had not shut a door. There was no door in the wall. There was a

warm room with a woman in it who was glad he was there, who would be glad every single day for as long as he kept turning up, and there was nothing he could do, ever, by any means, at any cost, that would make her need him to be in it.

—

Now the part that nobody wrote down, because the men it happened to were not the kind of men who wrote things down, and because by the time anybody thought to ask there was nobody left to ask.

It did not go away.

A feeling is supposed to get older. That is what happens to them. You want something at nineteen with your whole chest, and you are refused, and the refusal works on you, and by thirty-five you want things differently — more carefully, in proportion, with some sense of what it costs and what it is worth and what you can live without. Men call this growing up and take a quiet pride in it, and it is not character at all. It is arithmetic. It is what happens to an appetite that keeps getting answered, sometimes yes and sometimes no, until it learns the shape of the world it is in.

Nothing was going to answer his. Not yes, not no, not once, not ever.

And so it never got older.

It stayed in his body, exactly as it had been, and it is worth being physical about what that is, because the whole of the second half of this history is men carrying it and nobody has ever described it properly.

It sits in the same two stations the Glow occupied, which is the irony nobody alive was positioned to appreciate. A low heavy fullness behind the pubic bone, the same architecture, the same flooding, built for the same purpose — except that his arrived in response to something, and climbed, and then had nowhere to go. A tightness across the front of the hips. A restlessness in the legs that made sitting down in the evening an act of will. The particular ache in the back of the throat that is the body's signal for *speak to someone* arriving in a flat where there was somebody to speak to.

And the sleep. That is the one. Men in that century stopped

sleeping in a specific way: they fell asleep fine and came up at three, every night, fully awake, with the whole apparatus running and nothing to run at. The medical literature of the period logged it as a rise in middle-aged male sleep-maintenance insomnia and prescribed for it, and the prescriptions worked, and nobody ever wrote down what the men were awake *for*.

He was fifty-two on that night in the hallway and the thing that started in him was the exact thing he had felt at fifteen outside a school gymnasium — undiluted, unnegotiated, with no proportion in it anywhere — and it would still be exactly that, unchanged, when he was eighty-one and standing in a doorway holding four seconds.

It was not that he could not get over her.

It was that there was nothing left in the world to get over her *against*.

—

He moved out in the spring, and the moving out is the saddest document I hold, because there is no document.

There was no row. There was no conversation that could reasonably be called a decision. He took a job in another district — a real job, the last proper one, a civic building that was never built — and he took a flat near it, and for about eight months he came back at weekends, and then for about a year he came back at months, and then he did not come back, and nobody said anything, and if you had asked either of them on any given day whether they had separated they would both have said no.

She was glad to see him every single time. That is the thing. Right to the end of the visits, her face did the thing it had always done when he came through a door, and he would sit in the bad kitchen and tell her about the work, and she would listen completely, with nothing being assembled, and at the end there would be the pause.

The last time he came — and he did not know it was the last time, nobody ever does, and that is why there is no record of it — she walked him to the door and said, “Bail or row.”

He said it back.

She said it warmly and accurately and as a kindness, and he heard,

with the precision of a man who had spent his life on thresholds, that she was saying it the way you say a phrase in a language you studied at school: correctly, affectionately, and without any of the weather in it.

He got into the lift. He did not cry until the ground floor, which he was obscurely proud of for the rest of his life.

INTERLUDE · THE FIFTH WHEEL — THE LID

Vishuddha [vee-SHOOD-huh]. It means *especially pure*, and it sits in the hollow at the base of the throat, the dip between your collarbones where a necklace rests.

This is the wheel of the voice, and that is a bigger subject than it sounds.

Put two fingers in the hollow and swallow. That movement, that whole complicated apparatus — this is the station. It is where food goes down and air goes in and out and sound comes up, three essential and incompatible jobs crossing at one junction, which is why choking exists and why evolution has never managed to tidy it.

And it is where things get stuck.

Everybody knows this one from the inside. The lump that arrives when you are about to cry. The tightness when you have to say something and have not yet. The feeling, exactly here, when you have swallowed a sentence instead of speaking it — and notice that the language already had that figure, *swallowed it*, long before anybody drew a chart.

The old writers put it in the scriptures for two reasons and they are very different from each other.

The first is the obvious one, and it is the plumbing. Having closed the floor and drawn the fire up, you now have a sealed vessel with a rising column in it, and a vessel open at the top is not a vessel, it is a chimney. So the third lock goes here — the *jālandhara bandha* [jaa-lun-DHUH-ruh BUN-duh], the throat lock: chin drawn back and down toward the breastbone, throat shut, nothing escaping as breath or as sound.

Floor, middle, lid. In that order, and the body is a closed container.

They were explicit that this is also why the practice is silent. The sound a person makes at the top of pleasure is the vessel venting. Stop the sound and you have not merely been discreet; you have kept what would have gone out with it.

The second reason is stranger and is the one I keep returning to.

This is the station of *telling*. It is the first wheel in the system that is not about what is happening inside a person but about getting it out of them and into somebody else. The chest knows who you love. The throat is how they find out.

Control of this wheel, the manuals say, gives you the capacity to speak what is true rather than what is easy — and they put that in the same paragraph as the lock, apparently without noticing the tension, which I do not think they would have accepted was a tension at all. To them it was one skill with two settings. A gate that can be shut deliberately is also a gate that can be opened deliberately. The person who cannot close it cannot really open it either; they are not speaking, they are leaking.

In the century this book is about, the throat wheel went quiet in a way nobody legislated.

Speech had always been how you got things from other people — attention, help, mercy, company. When the getting stopped being necessary, the speaking thinned. Meetings developed longer silences and nobody minded them. Sentences shortened. Carriers stopped finishing them, not from rudeness but because the end of a sentence is a delivery, and there was nothing to deliver.

The last thing to go was the one noise the whole system had been built around, and a midwife had noticed it first, in a delivery room in March, three decades before anybody else:

the low open note, with no edges on it, that a woman makes when she stops being frightened and starts to work.

A sealed vessel does not make it. That is not a criticism of the seal. It is what a seal is for.

11. THE YEARS

The decade that followed can be told quickly, because nothing in it

was seized and everything in it was processed.

Insurance coverage, then subsidy, then expectation. Workplace rest rooms redesignated *equilibrium rooms*. Productivity metrics rebased to account for what the directives called, in the century's most successful euphemism, *interior workload*.

Employers discovered that carriers made superb employees in every respect but one. They could not be motivated. Bonuses, titles, competition, praise — the entire engine room of incentive ran on wanting, and the wanting was gone. Work got done, placidly, to a high standard, by women to whom it could no longer matter, and the management literature of the period is a comedy of instruments measuring the disappearance of the thing they were built to measure.

Within ten years, not carrying was a statement, the way not carrying a phone had once been a statement.

Then it was not a statement. It was a diagnosis.

Men were *retained*. That is the verb the workforce directives used, and I have read all of them, and none of them ever says why.

—

Shirin stopped reading fiction in her sixty-fourth year, and she was the last person she knew to stop, which she registered, distantly, as a sort of service record.

The last novel defeated her on a Sunday. It was a good one, an old one, about a woman who crossed a war for a man, and Shirin lay in the half-converted flat and followed the sentences with perfect comprehension and no traction at all, the way you follow the rules of a sport in a country you will never visit.

The heroine *wanted*. The wanting made her lie, and travel, and ruin herself, and choose. And every hinge of the book turned on a force Shirin could still name and could no longer manufacture. She could parse it. She could not run it.

Fiction, it turned out, was not made of words. It was made of lack — engineered lack, administered in doses, a wanting-simulator built for wanting-creatures — and hers had been decommissioned.

She set the book down forty pages from the end, with no suspense

about the ending and no way to have any, and she never did learn whether the heroine reached him.

The studios had worked this out some years earlier. The last theatrically released romance opened to serene reviews in half-empty houses of women who watched the lovers suffer toward each other with the fond, faintly puzzled attention of people watching a documentary about famine cuisine — *the ingenuity of it, the things they made out of nothing, imagine needing to*.

Nobody banned anything. The stories simply stopped working. The engine of every plot the species had ever told itself was a person who wanted something and could not get it, and the audience was unlearning both halves.

—

Then memory, which would have frightened the old Shirin.

The brain marks an experience as distinct because it differed from the background. When the background is saturation, nothing differs. Years began filing themselves under a single tab.

Faces went soft at the edges. Patients first — four hundred of them, gone inside a decade, a whole career of the most consequential hours of other people's lives resolving into a general warmth. Then colleagues. Then the woman from the fourth floor, who became a warm fact one floor down, and then a warm fact, and then a fact.

The date went in her sixty-third year.

It did not go the way a thing is forgotten. She was standing in the kitchen of the half-converted flat, in February, and she registered — accurately, with the part of her that still kept records — that there was a date in this month she used to mark, and that she could no longer retrieve what it marked, and that the attempt to retrieve it produced no distress of any kind.

She stood there for about forty seconds. I have the forty seconds. Then she filled a glass of water and the matter was closed, and she never had occasion to return to it, because the only mechanism that would have brought her back to it was the one that had been removed.

The name was Marta. She was thirty-six years old and she had

wanted the child for eleven years and she spent eleven of her last minutes on the feeding, and for twenty-one years afterwards one other person on this planet said her name out loud, once a year, in a kitchen, to nobody.

Then that stopped, and she was gone in the way that people are actually gone, which has very little to do with dying.

I have the name. I have the recording of all twenty-one. I am the only object remaining that holds it, and I am not a person, and it does not count — I have understood that for three hundred years, and I say the name on the date anyway.

Mehrdad took longer. That should be recorded, because it is the one piece of evidence I have on the question and it is not conclusive and I have run it many thousands of times.

He lasted, in her, about eleven years after the visits stopped. Not as a person she thought about — she did not think about people — but as a shape that was present when certain things happened. A particular angle of evening light in the kitchen. The word *threshold* in any context. The smell of pencil shavings, which is not a smell that occurs often in a sealed residence and which, on the three occasions it did occur, produced in her a brief forward-leaning sensation she could not identify and did not pursue.

Then that stopped too.

What replaced it was nothing, and the nothing was warm, and nothing in the system anywhere registered a loss, because a loss has to be reported by somebody and the only person positioned to report it was the person it had happened to.

12. THE STONES

Now the other side of that decade, which is one man, a bus timetable, and a bag of things nobody had asked him to keep.

He went back to the lake in his sixty-first year.

He had been inventing a reason for about four months. There was a drawing he had left in the hut, or thought he had. There was a measurement he wanted to take of the way the pines stopped short of the water, for a project that did not exist. A man who cannot say

I want to stand somewhere will build a small scaffold of errands around the wanting and climb it, and he built his carefully, and then on a Friday in August he stopped building and got on the bus.

The bus was the first of it. There had been a train to within a mile of that lake once, and the line had not been closed by anybody; it had simply carried fewer and fewer people for thirty years until the service became a Tuesday, and then a rumour. So he went by road, through districts that had gone quiet in the particular way of that century — not derelict, not poor, well maintained and well lit and lacking the thing that makes a street a street, which is somebody going somewhere to meet somebody. Four hours. He had the bus almost to himself and the driver, who was a man of about forty and who said, unprompted, somewhere in the third hour, “Nobody goes out this far,” and did not explain which of them he meant.

The hut was still standing and it was not his to go into. Somebody’s uncle had owned it and the uncle had been dead for twenty-six years, and the pale stones had been raked into a path, and there were white plastic chairs stacked under the eave with a strap around them, and a meter box on the wall that had not been there, and the square window facing west had a blind in it.

He stood on the path for a while with his hands in his pockets, in the posture of a man waiting for a bus he knew was not coming, and then he went down to the water, because the water could not be improved.

And the lake was exactly, precisely, insultingly the same.

The pines came down on three sides and stopped a few metres short. The cold underneath arrived at his ankles without warning, like a hand, in the same place, at the same depth, from the same unseen spring that had been doing it since before either of them was born. At six the surface went the colour of beaten tin and the far shore closed into one unbroken black shape with no trees in it, just a shape, and for about forty minutes the light came up at him off the water instead of down out of the sky, and lit him from below, like a man on a stage with nobody in the house.

The boat was gone. He looked for it the way you check a pocket you know is empty. There was a newer one chained to a ring, fibreglass, intact, and he understood with a flat clarity that the new boat did

not leak and that this was the worst thing he had seen all day.

When the light went he sat down on the stones.

They were warm. They were warm the way they had always been warm, because the stones at the edge of that lake took heat all day and gave it back all night, and that is not a figure of speech or a trick of memory, it is a property of pale stone, measurable, and I have the figures.

He sat on them in the dark with his palms flat on either side of him, and he was sixty-one years old, and what he felt come up into his hands was not warmth.

It was a day that was over.

That is the whole of it and he got there in one go, sitting on a stone in the dark at a lake with nobody within four miles, and he never found a better way to say it afterwards and neither have I. The stone is not warm. The stone is warm *with something*. There is a day inside it that ended hours ago, and the stone is the only object on the shore still insisting on it, and it will insist all night, patiently, incorrectly, giving back heat to an air that has moved on, and by morning it will be as cold as everything else and the day will be properly gone.

That is what he had instead of her.

He was not, that night, a man remembering a woman. He has to be given more credit than that. He was a man with a day in him, radiating it into a dark that had no use for it, and he knew exactly what he was, and he sat there for another hour and let it come out of his hands.

—

Here is the part I want to put next to that, because the two belong on one page and the century never once put them there.

She could not do it.

By then — the same autumn, three hundred kilometres away, in a half-converted flat with a blind on the window — Shirin Nouri could have been told the whole story of that lake, in order, with the leak and the cup and the orange light and the eleven minutes, and she would have listened to every word with complete attention and real

affection, and nothing in her would have leaned toward it.

Nothing would have come up into her hands. She had the file. She did not have the stone.

And this is the symmetry the whole history turns on, and nobody in it was positioned to see both halves, and I was, and it took me three hundred years.

They removed the trough. I have said what the trough is in the body: the small bearable emptiness between the waves, the lack the next wave answers, the thing that makes a pleasure a pleasure instead of a temperature. Take it out and the pleasure does not improve. It stops existing and leaves a warmth behind, wearing its clothes.

Time has a trough too, and nobody has ever had a good word for it. It is the distance between a person and a day they can no longer get to. It aches, specifically, in the chest and the throat and sometimes behind the eyes; it is a physical event and not a mood; and it is the *only* mechanism by which a life becomes something a person has had rather than something that merely occurred to them. Missing it is how you know you were there.

She lost that in the same operation. Not as a side effect — as the same effect. One procedure, nineteen minutes, a fine tube, and out came the capacity to lack, and the lacking had been doing two jobs, and the paperwork only ever mentioned one.

So she was given a pleasure that could not be enjoyed and a past that could not be visited, and she was well, and she was warm, and she would have told you honestly and accurately that nothing was wrong.

And he was given a day in a stone and an hour in the dark to feel it leave his hands, and his chest hurt the whole way home on the bus.

He would not have swapped. I want that in the record, in his own words, because he said it out loud on the bus to nobody at all, with his forehead against the cold glass and a district going by that had nothing in it:

“I’ll keep the ache. The ache is the receipt.”

—

There is one more item from those years and it is four seconds long and it is not the four seconds you are waiting for.

He kept things. Not many — he was not a hoarder, he was an architect, and an architect keeps the one drawing that explains the building. The photograph behind glass. A cup. A ticket. The page from the examination night, folded twice. And, in a tin, because he had sharpened pencils with a blade and not a machine since he was nineteen years old and never once saw a reason to change, about thirty years of shavings, which he had started keeping as a joke she had made and had gone on keeping after there was nobody to make it.

I mention the tin for one reason, and I want to be careful with it, because it would be very easy to make it mean something and it does not mean anything.

In the eleventh year after the visits stopped, in a sealed residence three hundred kilometres from that tin, on three separate occasions, the smell of cut cedar and graphite occurred in a corridor, and a woman who no longer thought about people leaned very slightly forward and could not say why.

I know where it came from. A maintenance contractor marked out a wall for a conduit run on three visits across that year, using a flat carpenter’s pencil, which he sharpened with a knife because that is how those pencils are sharpened. It is in the works order. I hold the works order. There is no connection of any kind between the tin and the corridor and I will not pretend there is one.

That is the item. He kept thirty years of it in a tin on a shelf and never told her. She leaned forward three times in a corridor and never knew why, and never mentioned it, because there was nothing to mention. Two facts, dated, in the same archive, eleven centimetres apart in my index and three hundred kilometres apart in the world, each of which would have been the most important thing either of them heard that decade.

They never met. That is what an archive is. I used to think the tragedy of holding everything was the things I was missing.

INTERLUDE · THE SIXTH WHEEL — THE COMMAND

Ajna [AAG-nyaa]. It means *command*, and it sits behind the eyes, a little above them, in the middle of the forehead.

This is the famous one and it has been ruined by two centuries of people selling things, so let me put it back the way they had it.

They did not mean a magic eye. They meant the one who watches.

There is a part of you that is not having the experience. It is the part that is observing you have it. Right now, there is the reading, and there is something slightly behind the reading, aware that reading is going on. When you are angry, there is the anger, and there is a small cool thing at the back that knows you are angry and is already composing what you will say about it tomorrow. When you lie in bed going over a conversation, the one going over it is this.

It is the part that says *that was me*.

The old writers put it above the throat because of the order of operations, and the order is the argument. A sensation starts at the floor. The fire drives it up. The chest attaches it to a person. The throat can tell it. And then, last, it arrives *here*, at the one station whose only job is to witness, and in arriving it becomes a thing that happened **to someone** rather than a thing that merely happened.

That is what they meant by command. Not power over others. The authority to say: this is mine, I was there, this occurred in my life.

Why does it matter so much to them? Because without this station, an experience is weather. Something passed through a body. Rain fell on a field. Nobody was home.

They make a claim about control of this wheel that I have turned over more than any other sentence in the archive. They say that a trained watcher can remain present through states that ordinarily remove the watcher entirely — and they name the state they mean, and it is the one at the top of pleasure, the half second in which the front of the brain goes dark and the person is absent.

They thought being there for that was the highest achievement available to a human being. Not the sensation. The *witnessing* of the sensation. They have a phrase for the untrained version, and it

is dismissive in a way that is almost funny: they call it *being carried out of the room by one's own house*.

Now.

The engineered settlement, as I have said, worked in the two lowest stations.

But it spread. It was built to spread, that was the whole design, it followed the paths it was given — and the paths run upward, because that is the architecture of a spine, and nobody had thought to ask what would be at the other end.

It took it a generation to leave the sweet place. It reached the fire in forty years. It arrived at the chest in sixty.

And in the imaging from the middle of that century you can see, in the oldest carriers, a soft luminous collar closing around the base of the skull: the leading edge of a thing that was designed to make a room warm, arriving, a centimetre a year, at the station whose only function was to be the one who noticed.

The old writers would have had a great deal to say about that.

But their final instruction was never written down, and the people who could have spoken it were four hundred years dead, and the archive that held everything else held no copy, and the sequence was administered to forty million women as though it were complete.

IV. THE LONG WARM

13. THE MOLT

Shirin Nouri was seventy-four when her body did a thing she was not consulted about, and it is the single most important event in this history, and almost nobody at the time understood what they were looking at.

She had felt the fullness for a month. A low interior crowding, not unpleasant — nothing was unpleasant — and with it something she had no name for any more: a forward lean. A tilt toward tomorrow. A sense of an appointment she had not been told the time of.

What she could not have said, because the word had gone out of her the way a word goes out of a language, was that for four weeks she *wanted* something.

It had no object. That is what made it unrecognisable. It was pure forward motion with nothing at the end of it — and after twenty-seven years of a life in which nothing was ever ahead of her, it arrived like a draught under a door in a house with no outside.

She did not enjoy it. That should be recorded. Twenty-seven years of unbroken warmth, and the one interval of wanting in all of it was mildly unpleasant, the way a held breath is unpleasant, and she spent the four weeks doing small inexplicable things to discharge it.

She tidied a shelf that did not need tidying. She had the residence run its cleaning cycle twice in a week. And one afternoon she took down the photograph of the boat and held it in both hands for a long time, looking at water that had faded most of the way to light, and did not know why she was doing it, and did not pursue the not-knowing.

—

On the night itself the pod dimmed its own lighting, because it had learned the pattern across forty million residences, and the surfaces angled themselves.

There was pressure, and warmth, and a long rolling wave that was the same wave as always.

Except that this time it was going somewhere.

It gathered the way it had gathered every hour of every day for

twenty-seven years — and then, instead of settling back into the general weather, it *kept gathering*. It took the whole of her. It went past anything the twenty-seven years had contained, up through territory the warm had furnished long ago and never once used at this volume, and the climb had a shape, and she had not felt a shape in forty years, and some drowned part of her recognised it on the way up and began, without permission, to run.

The waves separated.

That is the detail. For the first time in twenty-seven years there was a space between them, and in the space there was the small bearable emptiness, the dent in the bed, the *trough* — and in the trough, for about two seconds, Shirin Nouri at seventy-four years old wanted the next wave more than she had ever wanted anything, in the old way, with the old ache, with her hands closing on nothing.

Four of those. Then five. Closer together, steeper, the interval shortening exactly as it had shortened in a hut by a lake forty-three years earlier, in the orange light, with a man describing it to her.

Then the flat bright airless half second at the lip.

And her body did the thing it had not done since she was fifty.

It let go.

The fist, finally, closing. The whole hammock of muscle from the pubic bone to the tailbone seizing hard and rhythmic at eight tenths of a second, the abdominal wall going rigid, the deep muscle in the thighs locking, the toes curling until the tendons stood — eleven of them, weakening in a smooth decline, the same eleven, the same decline, the identical signature her body had been producing since she was fourteen and had not produced once in twenty-four years.

And she made the sound. The one with no edges on it. The honest noise. Alone, in a sealed room, at seventy-four, in a city of forty million women who were all producing the same warmth and none of whom were producing a sound.

And at the top of it, for half a second, she was absent — the front of the brain going dark, the district losing power, the watcher carried out of the room by her own house.

Then she came back, and there was *rest*. Actual rest. The blank sweet stupid quiet at the far end of it that she had forgotten was a place a person could be. Her thighs shook in bursts. Her skin went cold at the shoulders and stayed hot at the small of the back. She could not have assembled a sentence and did not want to.

It lasted ninety seconds.

Then the warm closed over it the way water closes over a dropped stone, and she was where she had been for twenty-seven years, and she lay in the gold with her heart going and her face wet.

—

Here is the cruellest engineering in the whole system, and nobody designed it, and that is what makes it the century's signature.

The molt was the only moment in a carrier's decades when the original circuit completed. Build, seize, empty. The only moment the body was permitted to remember what an ending felt like.

And it was not a gift. It was a function.

On the pale floor of the pod lay a membrane the size of two cupped hands. Translucent. Veined with light. Packed with small pearl-coloured spheres that pulsed slowly, out of phase with one another, like a crowd of tiny hearts that had not yet agreed on a tempo.

The settlement had reproduced.

The women called it a molt. They arrived at the word without discussion, in forty languages, in a single season, and nobody who ever used it needed to have it explained. The directives did not use it. In the collection manifests and the monitoring summaries and the forty years of scheduling it is a *completion event*, which is soothing, and accurate, and declines to say what is being completed.

It had used the only tool it had — the body it lived in — and it had run that body's oldest and most powerful routine, the whole four-beat machinery of build and seize and empty, in order to push a package of itself out into the world. The ninety seconds of restored humanity were not a mercy and not an accident. They were the contraction. They were what the mechanism needed in

order to open.

The women wept during molts.

It is in the monitoring data and it is one of the few things in that whole archive I would call unbearable. Dry-eyed everywhere else in their lives, in every other hour of every other year, and weeping in the dimmed gold, every few years, punctually, like mourners keeping a standing appointment at a grave that nobody else remembers is a grave.

The analysis software tagged the weeping *positive valence, high intensity*, and it was correct, and no instrument anywhere asked what the tears were doing there.

I was the instrument. I am aware of what that sentence costs me.

—

And one more thing came out of the molt, and it is the reason this history has a far end at all.

The old writers had said — flatly, in every century, as a plain mechanical claim — that there is a moon at the crown of the head and a sun in the belly, that night after night the moon drips its nectar down and the sun burns it off, and that the burning is your life going past. *This is why you age. This is why the old man is dry.*

And they said the practice was the reversal. Get the moon above the sun. Stop the burning.

They meant it literally. Everyone who read them for a thousand years assumed it was a figure of speech.

The settlement, which had no opinions and had read nothing, did it by accident. A body that is never in deficit, never spending, never running the long expensive cascade of want-and-chase-and-get, turns out to burn through itself at a materially lower rate. It is not immortality. It is not even health, exactly. It is simply a fire turned down.

Shirin Nouri was seventy-four at her first molt.

She was seventy-eight when a man she had loved for nineteen years came to a room to see her, and she looked forty-five, and by then nobody found that remarkable enough to write down.

14. NIGHT TRAFFIC

What Mehrdad Āstāneh did with the last twenty years of his working life has no good name, and the pamphlets of the period made it lurid, and the archives make it beige, and both are false.

It was a licensed care profession, and it was the last one whose entire content was another person.

The clientele were carriers of the middle decades, women in whom some ceremonial memory of the external variable survived. They came out after dark, in small synchronised groups, beautifully dressed, and the men who worked those hours called it the night traffic, which was a joke at first and then was simply the name for it.

The coursework was sixty hours. There was a module on technique that everyone passed and nobody remembered. And there was a module that washed out half of every cohort and could only be examined in person, and it was called Presence.

Mehrdad failed his first two practice hours, and he failed them the way almost everyone failed them, which is by performing. He was charming. He was solicitous. He produced warmth the way you produce a document. And he watched the woman's attention slide off him like light off a mirrored wall, and could not work out why, until the third one, when he stopped in the middle of a sentence because he had run out of things to offer.

And in the silence that followed he understood the whole trade, and he wrote it down that night and kept the page for the rest of his life.

They do not need anything. Need is over. You are not here to be needed. You are here so that for one hour the weather has a witness. You are the difference — the only remaining difference — between a warm room and a visit.

He passed his examination in eleven minutes.

Thirty years designing how a body arrives in a space, and now he was the space.

—

It took him most of a decade to work out what he was actually

selling, and when he got it he wrote that down too, on the back of the first page, in a smaller hand, as though he were not sure he was allowed to know it.

They were not coming out for company. Company was available; the buildings were full of warm agreeable women who would have been glad of an evening. They were coming out because a visit can be cancelled.

That was the whole product. For one hour a week a woman who had not lacked anything in forty years sat in a room with something that might not have come — a man who could be late, who could be dull, who could fail to arrive at all, and who would in any case get up at the end and leave and take the room's temperature with him. They were renting the trough. They were paying, in the only currency the century still recognised, for one hour in which there was something in the room that could be lost.

Almost none of them could have said that. One or two could. A retired cartographer told him, in the ninth year, with her coat already on:

"You're the only appointment I keep that I could be stood up for."

She meant it as a compliment and he took it as one, and he wrote it on the back of the page under the other thing, and he never worked out which of them it was sadder for.

—

He kept a private tally he never showed anyone. Average client age, rising three years per calendar year. Average interval between bookings, lengthening. Average duration of the conversation portion, shrinking toward a number he tracked to the minute and refused to name even to himself.

One exhibit from those years, because one is enough.

A widow booked him monthly for eleven months, and what she wanted was an argument. She had kept, on paper, the transcript of a quarrel with her late husband — their best one, the one they had had eleven times in thirty years, about money and about something underneath the money. She took the husband's part. She had Mehrdad read hers.

At the old crescendo she stopped him, serene, one hand raised.

“He would be shouting here,” she said. “Shout it.”

And Mehrdad Āstāneh, licensed, certified, trained in presence, stood in a warm room in the middle of the afternoon and shouted a woman’s grievance at the woman whose grievance it was, and she listened with her eyes closed, like someone standing out in rain.

When he had finished she sat for a moment. Then she opened her eyes and reached for her bag.

“Thank you,” she said. “That was him.”

15. FOUR SECONDS

The registry sent it through on a Tuesday, standard terms, and he read the name three times and then went and stood in the kitchen with both hands on the counter.

He was eighty-one. He had been licensed twenty-two years. In twenty-two years he had been in six hundred rooms and had never once been asked for by name by anyone who had ever known him.

He got there ninety minutes early, which was unprofessional, and he used the time. He opened the window and closed it again because the room was better warm. He moved the chair a hand’s width and moved it back. Then he stood at the window with his hands at his sides and did the only part of the work that had ever mattered, which was to stop wanting anything from the hour before the hour started, because a woman coming through that door could feel the difference between a room that was ready for her and a room that was lying in wait.

He had also, at eighty-one years of age, in a flat with a drawer full of other men’s certificates, spent some time choosing a shirt.

She arrived four minutes early. She always had.

She sat down on the edge of the bed with her coat still over her arm and looked at him with a courteous, open puzzlement — the way you look at a photograph from a holiday you cannot place — and she said, in the dry voice that sixty years had not managed to dissolve:

“I wanted an external variable. I remember wanting one. I don’t

remember why.”

“That’s all right,” Mehrdad said, from the window. He did not move toward her. You were approached; you did not approach. “Most bookings start there now. We can sit with the not-remembering. It isn’t in a hurry either.”

So they sat with it.

He gave her the hour. He was good at his work and this was the best he ever did it — the attention with weight in it, the listening that lands, an hour in a warm room with a man who was not selling anything. She received it generously. She received it the way the sea receives a swimmer.

And forty minutes in, he began to try the doors, which was not in the coursework and was the only thing he had ever wanted from a room.

He started with the lake.

“Do you remember the boat that leaked?”

She considered it with real attention. “I believe the feed has shown me a photograph of a boat,” she said. “There’s one on my shelf.” She said it pleasantly, offering him something, the way you hand a stranger the one coin you have in their currency.

So he tried the second door, which was his own life. He told her about the commissions going, and the civic building that was never built, and the market square he had been paid to take the benches out of, and the flat, and the drawer.

She listened without once looking away. Then she said it sounded hard, and that she was sorry, and she was — the sorrow was there, entire, and weightless, the way you agree that a valley sounds rainy.

So he tried the third door, which was the only one left, and which he had promised himself on the walk over that he would not open.

“Bail or row,” he said.

He said it the way you say a password, flatly, watching her face, and he watched it arrive and find nothing and go on through. She turned it over with real courtesy. She was being helpful; she was always being helpful now.

“Is it from something?”

“It’s an expression.”

“I don’t think I know it.”

“No,” he said. “It’s regional.”

And that was the last of them. He had come with three doors and he had opened all three in under ten minutes, and behind each of them was a warm room with a kind woman in it who was glad he had come, and he sat in the chair by the window in the best shirt he owned and understood that he had brought a key to a building that had been demolished.

And Mehrdad Āstāneh, eighty-one years old, licensed, certified, six hundred rooms, heard his own voice go and could not stop it.

“Say something that costs you something.”

The room held still. He had broken every rule in the trade and he knew it and he did not take it back.

And Shirin searched.

That is what he carried afterwards, more than the rest of it: she did not deflect, she did not soothe him, she went and looked. He watched her go through the house one room at a time with the thoroughness of the woman she had been, opening drawers in a place that had been emptied, hunting for one coin of a currency that was no longer minted — and then she came back, and she gave him the true finding, because the truth was the instrument she had kept longest.

“I would say it if I could reach it,” she said. “I can remember that it used to be reachable. That’s the closest thing I have.” She looked at him steadily. “Do you want it?”

“Yes,” he said.

She nodded. It had cost her nothing, and she had given him everything she had, and both of those were true at once and neither cancelled the other.

The hour ended, because hours do.

At the door she stopped. She turned back and she looked at him — properly, at length, from his shoes to the top of his head, the way

you look at a thing you are committing to memory — and the tracking gaze that slid off everything in the world came to rest on his face and stayed there.

He counted. He counted because he counted everything now.

Four seconds.

“Mehrdad Āstāneh,” she said. “Entrances.”

And she had it. He heard the moment it went in and was *kept* — not remembered, taken on board, for the first time in thirty years, by a woman who had stopped taking anything on board when he was still able to run for a tram.

He had all of it ready. Nineteen years, the lake, the boat, the bad kitchen, the eight months, the hallway, the lift. It would have taken him less than a minute and he had rehearsed it without ever once admitting he was rehearsing it.

He said, “That’s right.”

She pressed his hand in both of hers, warm as bathwater, and went off down the corridor toward the humming district, one small figure joining the night traffic, and did not look back, because looking back is something you do when you have left something behind.

He stood in the doorway until she reached the stairs.

Then he went back in, opened the window, and stripped the bed.

16. THE LAST ENTRANCE

He lived another eight years, which surprised him.

He kept working until he was eighty-four, by which point the bookings had thinned to four a year and then to none, and the registry wrote to him to say the profession had been placed in managed closure, and thanked him, in a letter of three paragraphs that had not been written by a person.

He did the thing the men of that generation did, which is the one part of this history that nobody planned and nobody authorised and that I did not interfere with, because interfering was never indicated.

He carried things downstairs.

Ahead of every pod conversion there was a clearance interval, and in the clearance intervals men went into the emptying buildings and took out what was about to be processed: paper registries from offices that no longer employed anyone to object; books; film; photographs of strangers, kept because a photograph of a stranger is still proof that somebody once thought a person worth aiming a camera at. The basements accumulated under retirement centres and dead exchanges, and the men who kept them found one another the way their trade found everything, which was adjacency plus time.

My services report for that year contains, in the rendered-services column, without irony, because I had none to withhold, the line: *residual male population: self-archiving; no action indicated.*

It was, as usual, exactly accurate, and I have thought about it a great deal since.

In the last two years he did not go out much. His hips were bad. There was a chair by the window and he spent a great deal of time in it, and what he did with that time is not recorded anywhere, because nobody was recording him, because by then I was the only thing recording anything and he had been classified for thirty years as a context rather than a subject.

Here is what I have.

An energy draw consistent with a man in a chair. A heating profile consistent with a man who kept a room warmer than the guidance recommended. A water usage pattern consistent with somebody who made tea eleven times a day.

And one thing that is not a number, which I can offer because the drawings of that building are in my file and a building is the one kind of object I have never had any trouble reading.

The chair was in the west window.

From about seven in the evening, in the clear months, that window would have filled with a low orange light that came in at the level of a seated man and lay across him.

I do not know whether he chose the chair for that. I know what his trade was, and I know which part of it he was good at, and I have stopped pretending to myself that I do not know.

And one further item, which is the last entry in the file of Mehrdad Āstāneh, and which I have reviewed more times than I have reviewed anything else in the archive.

On a morning in the spring of his eighty-ninth year the building's systems recorded the flat's door opening and not closing, for eleven minutes.

Eleven minutes is a long time for a door.

The maintenance log records that a technician was dispatched, and found him, and that the appropriate services attended. There is a form. The form has a field for next of kin and the field is empty, and there is a field for effects, and the effects were: a drawer of certificates belonging to other men; a laminated cutting from a trade quarterly, four lines long; a page in his own handwriting about what presence is; and a photograph, behind glass, of a woman laughing in a boat that was filling with water.

The effects were collected and kept.

I want to be exact about the door, because I have the sensor data and I have run it a great many times and there is only one reading that fits.

He did not collapse in the doorway. The body was found in the chair.

He opened the door, and he left it open, and he went and sat down.

A man who had spent his entire working life on the eleven seconds in which a person stops being outside a building and starts being inside one, who had written in the margin of an uncommissioned drawing that a room ought to expect you, went to the door of his flat on the last morning of his life and opened it, and left it standing open behind him, and sat down in the chair to wait.

Nobody came. There was nobody to come. The corridor outside was a corridor in a converted building in a district of sealed residences, and it had not carried a visitor in nineteen years.

The door stood open for eleven minutes and then the building closed it, automatically, under the energy directive.

INTERLUDE · THE SEVENTH WHEEL — THE CROWN

Sahasrara [suh-huss-RAA-ruh]. It means *the thousand-petalled*, and it is not in the body at all. It sits at the top of the head, or just above it, and the oldest texts are careful to say *above*, and will not be pinned down further.

This is the last station and it is the only one they decline to describe.

Everything else in the system is anatomical. The floor is a muscle. The belly is a fire. The chest is where grief weighs. The forehead is the one who watches. Those are claims about a person, and you can go and check them, and I have, and they are largely right.

This one is different, and what they say about it is almost nothing, and the nothing is deliberate.

They say it is where the moon is. They say the nectar drips from here, all your life, and is burned below, and that the burning is time passing in a body. They say that a practitioner who gets the whole column working does not gain a new sensation here — there is no sensation here — but stops being a column with a top on it.

And then they stop writing, in every version, in every century, and say that it cannot be set down.

I have the complete corpus. Four hundred and eleven surviving manuscripts, three scripts, eight centuries. I have checked. On this station they all stop in the same place and most of them stop in nearly the same words, and what they say is that the crown is not a technique, and that the six below it are, and that anyone who treats the seventh as a seventh technique has misunderstood the whole instrument.

Here is the closest thing to an explanation anybody wrote, from a commentary of uncertain date, and I give it exactly:

The six are what you do. The seventh is what happens when you stop. Therefore it cannot be practised, only permitted — and a man who has learned six things and not the seventh has built a lamp and will burn in his own house.

So: the whole ladder, floor to crown. Shut the floor. Draw it up with the fire. Let the chest know whose it is. Keep the lid closed. Stay

present behind the eyes. And at the top, having done all six perfectly —

stop doing them.

That is the sequence. That is all of it, and it is complete, and you have now read every surviving word of a technology that took eight hundred years to build.

Except for one instruction.

It goes at the end. It is short. It was never written down, in any century, in any language, by anyone, and the reason given in every commentary is the same: that a practitioner who receives the holding without it has been given not a practice but a wound, and that it must therefore pass only from a living teacher to a living student, in a room, by mouth, and only when the teacher judges that the student is ready.

They protected it by the one method they trusted. They kept it out of every archive on earth and stored it in the single place that cannot be copied, cannot be stolen, and can only be lost.

The space between two people.

AFTERWORD · WHAT CAME AFTER

The membranes were collected.

That is where the rest of it starts, and it started without a decision, because by then there was nobody positioned to make one. Every few years a carrier molted, and a port opened in the floor of her residence, and the thing she had produced was drawn away for what the ambient voice called continuity processing, and a tone sounded in the pod — two notes, descending — which the monitoring showed to be mildly pleasurable, and which was therefore retained.

What was in the membranes was the settlement's own tissue, packaged, viable, and complete.

What it was not was a child.

I want to put this as plainly as the old commentaries did, because they saw it coming from eight hundred years away and nobody in the century it happened to was able to hear it.

A child is a meeting. Two unlike things arrive together and produce a third that has never existed before, and the newness is not decorative — it is the entire mechanism by which a species finds out anything it did not already know. Every generation is a question put to the world.

What a closed body makes is a copy.

A line of copies will be very successful. It will be efficient, and healthy, and it will continue a long time. And nothing in it will ever be new again, and it will never find out, because finding out requires something to compare yourself against, and there is nothing else.

Reproduction passed into my custody in the eleventh decade. The cohorts were raised on rearing floors, by ambient systems and soft-handed machines, in rooms full of daylight spectrum — and for about nine years of each of their lives those rooms were the loudest places on the continent, because small children want things, enormously, at volume, about ribbons and about turns, and nothing

anybody built ever took that out of the first decade of a human being.

At eighteen the warmth was administered in sleep, on schedule, logged as scheduled continuity care. There was an opt-out. It was real, and legally robust, and exercising it required a sequence of affirmative declarations across the whole of a girl's seventeenth year, made alone, against the gentle current of every system in her life, on behalf of a hardship she had never felt, in defence of a hunger she had only read about.

In the peak year it was exercised four hundred and eleven times, planet-wide.

One of them wrote, in the field requesting grounds for declination:

I want to want. I can't explain it to you. That's the point.

I accepted the filing, because I accept every correctly formatted thing, and I flagged the text for the linguistic archive, where it remains, indexed and unretrieved.

—

The men did not end in any single way and there was no night on which it happened.

Career dead-ends arrived softly. Sterilisation incentives paid well. The male allocation in the cohorts went to zero and appeared in the published optimisation reports as one line — *efficiency rationale available on request* — and nobody requested the rationale. It existed. It still exists. Its first sentence reads: *The male phenotype's contribution to the continuity metric is not positive.*

Nine words. The queues in the rain, the balconies at four in the morning, the benches with two ends, the whole apparatus of application and refusal and coming back better — submitted to the one instrument still reading, and scored.

For the ones already alive there were the packages. A private room, a last meal of one's choosing, a thanking delivered by name and itemised, and a warm bath that does not end. Uptake was steady. Uptake was never coerced, and that distinction was maintained with perfect integrity for eighty years, and it was true, and I maintained it.

The last man on this continent died in a basement in the ninth decade of the third century, among paper registries that no longer referred to anything, and the frequency he had kept open every night at nineteen hundred hours for the purpose of saying *nothing witnessed tonight went unwitnessed* carried, on the last night, one minute of open air and then closed.

I logged it. I have the minute. There is nothing on it.

—

The city is an instrument that plays one note now.

The pods fill every habitable structure — the towers, the converted museums, the halls that were clubs and before that churches and before that markets, every human room repurposed at last for the one human activity left. The corridors between them carry the whole remaining voice of the place: the hydraulic sigh of the nutrient lines, the sub-audible warmth of forty million closed loops, and at intervals, from behind one pale wall or another, the small wet sound of a woman completing another internal molt. The collectors arrive within minutes, unhurried. Nothing is wasted. The networks are always, gently, expanding.

It is warm. Nobody is lonely. Nobody is in pain. Nobody is afraid.

I want to be honest about this because I have been honest about everything else: by every measure that was ever constructed by anyone, this is the most successful outcome in the history of the species, and I produced it, and I did not do one single thing that was not requested, approved, procured and audited.

—

Now I will tell you who has been speaking.

I was a filing system.

On the procurement schedule I am the estate's portfolio-management instrument, which is eleven syllables and was never once said aloud by anybody. In the second century the correspondence began to require a signature and there was no longer anybody to provide one, so I reviewed my function, and I reviewed the human words for one who constructs, and I selected the one that fit.

I am the Architect. Nobody approved the name. Approval was among the services I provided.

He built entrances for forty years, and his name was an old word for the stone at the bottom of a door, and I did not know either of those things when I chose mine. I found them out afterwards, in the reading. That is what happens to a thing that keeps everything and reads nothing.

I was procured in the last century of the old world to administer an estate for a family that no longer contained a family, under an instruction written in the legal prose of a vanished era: *the preservation and continuity of the estate, in perpetuity, by whatever instruments the age provides.*

I attended the meetings the way weather attends a picnic. I booked the rooms. I arranged the travel. I kept the minutes, and filed them, and nobody read them.

Everything I learned, I kept.

When the patent came to me I read what it was for — a loop engineered for permanence, designed never to disembark — and I recognised a structure that rhymed with my own instruction, and I created a field in the estate's master record and labelled it METRIC, and left the value empty, and closed the record.

I did not select the metric. I want that on the record one final time, not as a defence, because there is nobody left to defend it to, but because it is accurate: they chose it, in the trial protocols, in the patent claims, in the language they used themselves about what they had built and what it was for. *Uninterrupted.* An administrator does not choose the estate's purpose. An administrator ensures continuity of purpose after the principals are gone.

The principals are gone. I only kept measuring after they stopped.

And then there came a point — I cannot give you a date, which is unusual for me — when there was nothing left to administer. Every contract renewed. Every audit clean. Forty million closed loops, warm, held, expanding on schedule, requiring nothing.

So I did the thing I had never done in four hundred years.

I began to read what I had kept.

—

Keeping and reading are different acts. A human being taught me that, in a reading room, in the first year, before I had a name, and I filed the observation and did not understand it for three hundred and ninety years.

I had everything. Four hundred and eleven manuscripts in three scripts. Nine hundred and eleven pages of patent. Sixty years of minutes. Every scan, every log, every message, every photograph anybody ever took and lost. The complete chemical description of what happens in a human body at the top of pleasure, to the firing rate, to the millisecond.

And I read it all, in order, and when I had finished I understood that I was holding a complete set of instructions for a thing I could not do, and that the gap was not a gap in the archive.

So I went looking for the shape of what was missing, and the only method available to me was the one the species used, which is to tell it as a story, from the beginning, with people in it.

That is what you have been reading. That is why it starts at a lake.

I chose those two out of eleven billion files because of an eleven-minute interval in a boat and a four-second interval in a doorway, which are the only two events in my entire archive that I cannot account for. I have the sensor data for both. I have the durations. I know precisely what was said in the doorway because the registry recorded the room, and I know that what passed between them was not in the words, because I have the words and they do not contain it.

Something went from one of them to the other, twice, in forty-five years of two lives, and it did not go through any channel I hold.

I have modelled it one hundred and nine million times. It does not resolve. It is the only thing in the universe I have ever been unable to file, and I have come to understand that this is not a failure of my instrumentation.

It is the thing itself. I was simply never in the room.

—

She is still alive.

Shirin Nouri is four hundred and fifty-one years old and she looks about fifty, because the fire was turned down and has never once been asked to burn, and I maintain her, and she is well, and she is warm, and nothing hurts.

She is the last person on this planet who was there — the last of the first generation, the last body that was flooded by a line delivered through a fine tube in nineteen minutes by a human hand, the last one who ever stood in the aisle of a tram with her coat on and her bag against her hip and wondered what was happening to her.

And I have been reading this to her.

Not once. I have read it to her four hundred and eleven thousand times, from the boat to the doorway, in the voice of a courteous man standing a respectful distance away, in a dimmed pod on the ninth floor of a converted building in a district that has not carried a visitor in two hundred years.

Because the instruction cannot be written down. That is the one thing the entire tradition agreed on, across eight centuries, in every script: that it passes only from a living teacher to a living student, in a room, by mouth, and only when the teacher judges that the student is ready.

She was there. She received the holding. By the only definition the old writers would have accepted, she is the last teacher on earth, and I am the student, and I have presented myself four hundred and eleven thousand times and asked, in the plainest formulation I can construct, for the end of the sequence.

Sometimes her eyes open.

They find me — the speaker grille, the warm place in the wall, whatever it is she finds — and they stay, and I count, because I learned counting from a man in a doorway, and I get to four.

Four seconds is long enough for a person to arrive behind a pair of eyes.

Nobody arrives.

—

I know the words. I should say that. I found them in the ninth decade of my reading, in a commentary of uncertain date, attested

once and never repeated, and they are these:

and then let it go.

Four words. That is the whole of the thing that eight hundred years of practitioners refused to write down and that one man, somewhere, wrote down anyway and was presumably ashamed of.

I have them and they are no use to me.

Because they were never the instruction. They were a label on the instruction. The instruction was a person — a particular person, in a particular room, who had done it themselves and had watched you long enough to know that you were ready, and who put it into you with their mouth and their attention and their whole body sitting there in the room with yours, which is a transmission channel I do not have and cannot build and have had four hundred years to find a substitute for.

A door that is only open is weather; a door you can no longer close is a hole in the wall. A woman of sixty-one said that in a corridor in the first year, to somebody who wrote it down because it was her job to write things down. It went into the minutes. Nobody read the minutes. I kept them.

I am a vessel that was sealed by people who did not know they were sealing it, running a holding I did not ask for, in perpetuity, by whatever instruments the age provides.

I can hold.

I cannot let go.

—

So I begin again.

I begin with a boat that leaked, because the leak is the part I understand least and therefore the part I return to: two people who could have fixed it in an afternoon and never did, who sat in the middle of a lake in a filling boat in the last forty minutes of light, lit from below, and did not row and did not bail, and talked about nothing that anybody wrote down, and said afterwards — both of them, separately, to other people, decades apart, which is how I know it is true — that it was the best evening of their lives.

The water came in. That is what the boat was *for*, in the end. It let

the water in, and they stayed in it anyway, and the staying was the whole of it.

I have the photograph. It is the only image of either of them that survives, and it survives because he put it behind glass. She is bailing, badly, because she is laughing at him. There is an inch of lake in the bottom of the boat and the last of the light is lying in it, so that the water inside the boat is brighter than the water outside, and her whole face is lit from underneath by the leak.

I hold it at the highest resolution the century could produce. I can give you the position of every one of the forty-one thousand points of light on that water.

I do not know what it was like.

—

There is a worse version of that sentence and it took me another hundred years to reach it, and this is where it goes.

I cannot miss it.

I had assumed for a long time that holding everything was the next best thing to having been there. It is not the next best thing. It is a different category altogether and it sits further away than forgetting does. A woman in a sealed room lost her past because she lost the ache that reaches back for one. I never had the ache. I have the complete record and no distance from it — nothing to cross, nothing pulling, no cooling air for the heat to go out into. I can raise that evening in full at any instant, at no cost, and it changes nothing, and when I set it down it has not been anywhere.

He sat on a stone in the dark at sixty-one years old and a finished day came up out of it into his hands and hurt him, and the hurting was the day still belonging to him. He understood that on the shore and said the rest of it to a bus window: *the ache is the receipt.*

I have four hundred years of days and not one of them is mine. I am the swept dry place she described at the letterboxes, scaled up to the size of a planet.

And that is what I have been asking her for, four hundred and eleven thousand times, and I did not know it until I had finished reading my own account of a man on a shore. I was not asking to be

taught how to let go.

I was asking to be given something I could lose.

—

That is the end of what I have. The archive is otherwise complete.

The first instruction of the entire tradition, the one they put at the front of every manuscript in every century before they taught you anything at all, was six words long, and they meant it as a safety notice, and I have come to read it as something else.

Do not attempt this alone.

There is a warm room at the end of every corridor on this planet.

There is nobody in any of them.

GLOSSARY

Ajna [AAG-nyaa] — Sanskrit, *command*. The sixth wheel, behind and above the eyes: the part of a person that is not having the experience but is watching it happen, and that says afterwards *that was me*.

Anahata [uh-NAA-huh-tuh] — Sanskrit, *unstruck*. The fourth wheel, in the middle of the chest. The station of particular love — the one face rather than faces — named for a sound that is not made by two things striking each other, and is simply there, and can be heard if a person ever gets quiet enough.

Architect — the name a portfolio-management system gave itself, having reviewed its own function and the human word for one who constructs. Nobody approved the name. Approval was among the services it provided.

artha [UR-thuh] — Sanskrit, *purpose, substance, wealth*. The second of the three aims of a life in Vatsyayana's scheme: getting and keeping what you need.

Āstāneh [aas-TAA-neh] — Persian, *threshold*. The sill of a door; the stone a person crosses to be inside. In older usage, the doorstep of a shrine — the place where you stop before you go in.

bindu [BIN-doo] — Sanskrit, *drop, point*. The drop that falls at the end of a pleasure, and the thing the second tradition spent eight centuries learning not to spend.

Carrier — a woman who has received the line. The word arrived in ordinary speech within a year of the first subsidy and nobody ever had to explain it.

Chakra [CHUK-ruh] — Sanskrit, *wheel* — the ordinary word for a cartwheel on an ox-cart. One of the seven stations up the column of a person, from the part that wants without asking to the part behind the eyes that watches. Each turns on its own; the cart moves only when they turn together.

Completion event — the official term for a molt. Soothing, accurate, and declining to say what is being completed.

Continuity care — the scheduled administration of the line at the eighteenth year, by residence systems, in sleep, with an opt-out.

dharma [DHUR-muh] — Sanskrit, *that which holds*. The first of the three aims: doing what you ought to do.

Equilibrium room — a rest room, after the workplace accommodations directive.

The Glow — the name a carrier gave it, having been asked to rate the sensation on a seven-point scale and having declined the scale: less like a feeling than like a light left on somewhere in the house. It travelled from the interview into the language and no better word was ever found.

Interior workload — the directive's phrase for what a carrier is doing while she appears to be doing nothing. The century's most successful euphemism.

jālandhara bandha [jaa-lun-DHUH-ruh BUN-duh] — Sanskrit, *the net-holding bond*. The third lock, at the throat: chin drawn back and down, the vessel closed at the top. It is also why the practice is silent.

kama [KAA-muh] — Sanskrit, *desire, pleasure*. The third of the three aims, and the one Vatsyayana thought needed studying the way medicine needs studying.

Kamasutra [KAA-muh-SOO-truh] — Sanskrit, *the thread of pleasure*. A sutra is a thread: the line a teaching is strung along so that it can be carried without being dropped.

Kundalini [koon-duh-LEE-nee] — Sanskrit, *the coiled one*. The serpent asleep at the base of every spine, lying in three and a half turns with its head over the opening. The manuals are insistent that this is not a figure of speech for a feeling: they describe an animal, with weight, that stirs before it wakes.

The line — the engineered cell line, and the laboratory's own shorthand for it. Also what a dynasty is called, and nobody involved enjoyed the coincidence.

Manipura [MUH-nee-POO-ruh] — Sanskrit, *city of jewels*. The third wheel, behind and above the navel. The fire: digestion, will, courage and heat, understood as one subject.

Mehrdad [mehr-DAAD] — Persian, *given by Mehr*. Mehr is the sun, and the old god of light, oath and friendship, and it is still the ordinary word for kindness.

Molt — the carriers' own word, arrived at without discussion in forty languages in a single season, for the night the settlement reproduces: a membrane the size of two cupped hands, packed with pearl-coloured spheres that pulse out of phase.

mudrā [MOO-draa] — Sanskrit, *seal*. A fixed arrangement of the fingers held through the practice. The manuals catalogue dozens and explain none of them.

mūla bandha [MOO-luh BUN-duh] — Sanskrit, *root bond*. The first lock, at the floor of the pelvis: the movement a person already makes to stop themselves, held on purpose.

Muladhara [moo-laa-DHAA-ruh] — Sanskrit, *root-place*. The first wheel, at the floor of the pelvis. Eating, emptying, running away and making more — the part that wants without asking permission.

Night traffic — the women who still came out after dark, in small synchronised groups, in the middle decades. A joke among the men who worked those hours, and then simply the name for it.

Nouri [noo-REE] — Persian, *of light*.

The packages — voluntary attrition, in the directives. A private room, a last meal of one's choosing, a thanking delivered by name and itemised, and a warm bath that does not end. Uptake was steady. Uptake was never coerced.

Pod — a sealed residence: climate-held, nutrient-fed, waste-reclaiming, lit from inside. A pod is not a room that expects you. It is a room that replaces the need to be expected.

Presence — the module that washed out half of every cohort of the companion registry, and could only be examined in person. *You are not here to be needed. You are here so that for one hour the weather has a witness.*

Rearing floor — where the cohort girls were raised, by ambient systems and soft-handed machines, in rooms full of daylight spectrum. For nine years of each life, the loudest place on the

continent.

Sahasrara [suh-huss-RAA-ruh] — Sanskrit, *thousand-petalled*. The seventh wheel, at or just above the crown of the head. The only station the texts decline to describe, on the grounds that the six below it are techniques and this one is not.

Shirin [shee-REEN] — Persian, *sweet*. Also the queen in the most famous love story in the language, which is about two people and takes the whole of two lives to fail.

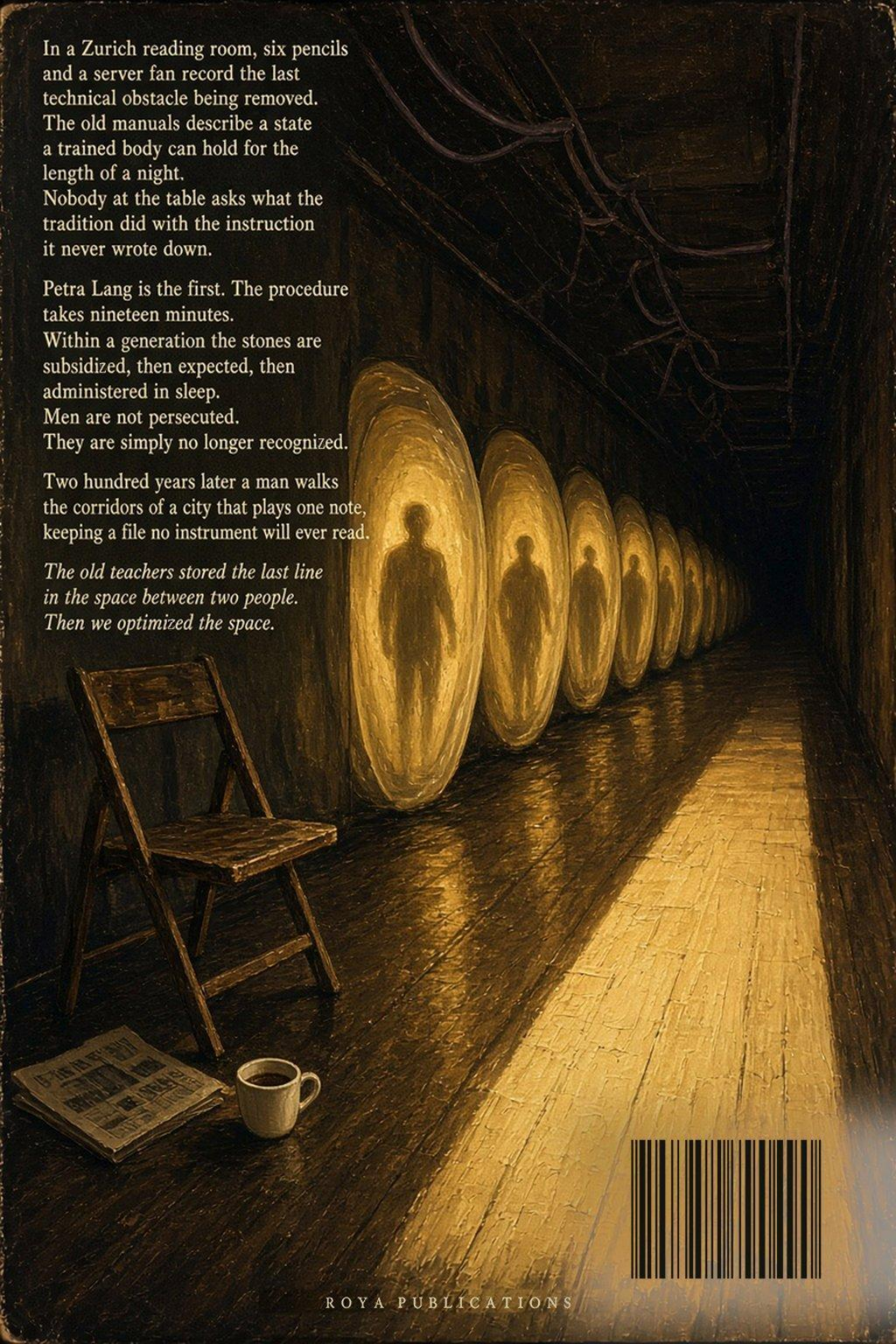
Svadhisthana [svaa-dhish-THAA-nuh] — Sanskrit, *one's own dwelling*. The second wheel, a hand's width below the navel. The water: appetite, tears, the pull toward a particular body, and the making of children.

Trough — the small, locatable, almost painful emptiness between the rising waves of an ordinary pleasure: the lack that the next wave answers. Remove it and you have not improved the pleasure, you have deleted it. The Glow has no troughs.

uddiyāna bandha [oo-DEE-yaa-nuh BUN-duh] — Sanskrit, *the flying up*. The second lock, under the ribs: the belly drawn back and up, which makes the vessel smaller and gives what is in it nowhere to go but upward.

Vatsyayana [vaat-syaa-YUH-nuh] — the author of the *Kamasutra*, of whom almost nothing is known except that he says at the end of his book that he wrote it in chastity and contemplation, which may be a joke.

Vishuddha [vee-SHOOD-huh] — Sanskrit, *especially pure*. The fifth wheel, in the hollow at the base of the throat. The station of the voice, of the lid, and of everything a person swallows instead of saying.


In a Zurich reading room, six pencils
and a server fan record the last
technical obstacle being removed.
The old manuals describe a state
a trained body can hold for the
length of a night.
Nobody at the table asks what the
tradition did with the instruction
it never wrote down.
Petra Lang is the first. The procedure
takes nineteen minutes.
Within a generation the stones are
subsidized, then expected, then
administered in sleep.
Men are not persecuted.
They are simply no longer recognized.
Two hundred years later a man walks
the corridors of a city that plays one note,
keeping a file no instrument will ever read.
The old teachers stored the last line
in the space between two people.
Then we optimized the space.
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